Friend of My Enemy: China, Iran and Their Unshared Adversaries

Shun Kwok

Abstract

This dissertation examines the strategic depth of Sino-Iranian relations by comparing China's security, economic, and political engagement with Iran to its ties with Iran's regional adversaries. Using empirical proxies—arms transfers (SIPRI TIV), bilateral trade data, and UN General Assembly voting alignment (κ and S-scores)—it finds that while China and Iran share rhetorical and ideological alignment, Beijing's tangible commitments remain limited. China prioritizes relationships with wealthier, less controversial Gulf states, engaging with Iran primarily when it serves low-cost strategic objectives. Sino-Iranian Relations are thus best characterized as pragmatic and limited rather than deep or committed.

Key Terms: BRI, BRICs, South–South cooperation, revisionism, civilizational discourse, energy security, Authoritarian Cooperation, Axis of Resistance, Iran-Iraq War, Nuclear proliferation, Strategic Autonomy, Multipolarity

Abbreviations

AIIB – Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank

BRI – Belt and Road Initiative

BRICS – Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa

GCC - Gulf Cooperation Council

IAEA - International Atomic Energy Agency

IRI – Islamic Republic of Iran

JCPOA - Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (Iran Nuclear Deal)

OBOR – One Belt, One Road

SCO – Shanghai Cooperation Organisation

SIPRI – Stockholm International Peace Research Institute

TIV – Trend Indicator Value

UNGA – United Nations General Assembly

WITS – World Integrated Trade Solution

I: Introduction

1.1: Friend of All, Friend of None?

We have no eternal allies, and we have no perpetual enemies. Our interests are eternal and perpetual, and those interests it is our duty to follow.Lord Palmerston, Speech in the House of Commons, 1848We have no eternal allies, and we have no perpetual enemies. Our interests are eternal and perpetual, and those interests it is our duty to follow.Lord Palmerston, Speech in the House of Commons, 1848

On paper, China and Iran appear to be closely aligned countries. Both are regarded as revisionist powers, keen to overthrow Western hegemony and establish a multipolar order where they enjoy

regional leadership. Economically, Beijing is Tehran's most significant trading partner, and both are members of BRICS and the SCO. From a security perspective, both are adversaries of the US-led international order, with some in the West going as far as to label them a "new axis of evil" alongside Russia and North Korea.[1] China and Iran, meanwhile, are fond of rhetorically elevating their mutual relations with the weight of history, as a rejuvenation of an ancient connection between two great civilizations.[2] Seemingly then, regardless of one's approach or perspective, Beijing and Tehran are ideal partners as both look to assert their place in the international system.

Yet this does not seem to be borne out in practice. Indeed, if there is any point of universal agreement within the literature, it is that relations between China and Iran are limited, cautious and calculated. Politically, China has refrained from overtly supporting Iran in regional disputes. Beijing supported multilateral initiatives to restrict Iran's nuclear program such as the JCPOA and has gradually diversified its imports and investments in the region away from the Islamic Republic.[3] For its part and despite its weaker position, Tehran's policy towards Beijing has generally been interpreted as explicitly transactional. These are actions hardly indicative of a high-quality alliance, and begs the question of why neither party has been willing to back up the other when push comes to shove.

The simple answer, as in most cases, is that there are more important concerns in play for both parties than their bilateral relationship. As the great power in this dynamic, China considers Iran, with all its regional aspirations, as merely one of many global partners; and one to which China has no critical resource dependencies. Tehran, in contrast, is aware of its relative weakness and has sought to limit its dependency on China. Yet bilateral Sino-Iranian relations are distinct from other friendly but limited partnerships due to a seeming conundrum. In a world conventionally divided into blocs, China and Iran both maintain closer relations with each other's adversaries than one might expect of two supposedly tight partners. Beijing enjoyed close relations with Saudi Arabia, the Gulf states and formerly Saddam's Iraq, while Iran has in turn historically maintained lukewarm relations with the Republic of China on Taiwan.

The adage has it that the enemy of your enemy is your friend. What then of a friend of your enemy? Is a friend of all by definition a friend of none? Does China's close partnerships with Iran's adversaries devalue its relations with Iran; and if so, how and in which aspects? This study aims to address these questions within the scope of Sino-Iranian Relations, along with the plethora of implications they carry. Currently, most of the existing literature on Sino-Iranian relations is insular and qualitative, providing much detail on events between Beijing and Tehran but little to situate them within the wider international context. By evaluating Sino-Iranian relations within a comparative regional paradigm, the study aims to help bridge this gap, allowing for a more objective evaluation of the strength of Sino-Iranian ties.

1.2: States, Supply Chains and Silkworms: A Multi-vector Methodology

To evaluate Sino-Iranian Relations within a comparative, quantitative framework as proposed in the introduction requires the resolution of several pre-requisite problems. These requirements determine the overarching structure of the study. In broad terms, the key driving questions are therefore as follows. First is the nature of China and Iran's overall foreign policy, as well as their broader regional strategy within each other's geopolitical area. This contextual background is necessary for determining the strategic objectives of each, and for a fuller understanding of the second prerequisite question regarding the nature of Sino-Iranian Relations. What are the key drivers behind their bilateral ties, and what concerns limit their geopolitical proximity? The identification of these factors is essential in the formulation and evaluation of the third and final question: how does the Sino-Iranian relationship compare to those of the respective nations with their counterparts' adversaries? The resolution of this final question will, in turn, provide insights regarding both Chinese and Iranian foreign policy and their bilateral relations.

Resolving these questions requires distinct theoretical and methodological approaches, and each will be the focus of a separate section. The first of these will address the nature of China and Iran's overall foreign policy objectives, focusing on how their objectives and praxis developed over time. This section is not intended to be ground-breaking, instead serving to provide the material and theoretical context necessary for the following investigation. As such a qualitative approach will be employed, with the emphasis placed on reviewing the perspectives and factors identified by the existing literature. Given the dramatic changes which occurred within Chinese and Iranian politics during the last half-century, a deliberate empirical-historical approach will be necessary to demonstrate the fundamental continuity within the foreign policy of both nations and therefore the justifiability of the historical-quantitative approach to be employed later.[4] Thus, this section will differ from conventional literature reviews in that the historiography of certain key events such as the Iran-Iraq War will be given due attention, at the expense of the finer theoretical nuances within Chinese and Iranian policymaking.

The next section will address Sino-Iranian Relations more specifically, looking at how the existing literature has framed relations between China and Iran in order to identify key drivers within their bilateral dynamic. Similar to the previous section, the purpose of the discussion is not to provide any new insight, but rather to elucidate the cases made in the existing literature for the ideological, geopolitical and economic considerations within their bilateral relationship. For practical purposes, the assumptions of the Rational Actor Model of Foreign Policy Analysis, that the state is composed of rational actors acting in its best interests and can thus be regarded as monolithic,[5] will be accepted as the theoretical baseline for this section.

The final three sections will deal with how the Sino-Iranian relationship compares with those the respective nations maintain with their counterparts' adversaries and the implications thereof. The first of these will focus on establishing one of the key assumptions of this study – that China and Iran have close relations with each other's adversaries, and that despite dramatic diplomatic shifts, their adversaries remain their adversaries due to the zero-sum logic of regional competition. Given the disparate nature of the subject, this section will continue to rely on the existing literature to create the qualitative and empirical basis for the following analysis section.

The following section will form the basis of this project's core contribution to the literature: that of quantifying the relative significance of Sino-Iranian Relations via a comparative evaluation vis a vis their respective adversaries. While the themes such as political alignment by which the comparison will be conducted will be derived from the existing literature, ontologically they will be represented

by empirical proxy factors ranging from SIPRI's arms transfer database to publicly disclosed trade and investment data. Theoretically, the proxy factors, while by definition imperfect representations, will be justified individually by reference to the allied economic and sociological fields of study in which they are commonly employed. The limitations of this materialist approach within international relations, that most complex of systems, will be the subject of a final subsection addressing potential mitigating factors and their representation within the model utilized.

Addressing the results and implications of the data collected in the previous section will be the subject of the final section, the first subsection of which will focus on analysing the immediate modelling, interpretation and presentation of the data in question. The second subsection will address the implications of these findings, thus resituating China and Iran's close partnerships with their counterparts' adversaries within the existing literature; and discuss some of the potential counterarguments and challenges that may be presented.

II: Literature Review

2.1: Status-quo Revisionism: Chinese Foreign Policy and the Middle East

Interpretation of China's foreign policy towards Iran has generally followed broader interpretations of its regional and overall policy objectives. It is therefore conducive to begin with a broad summary of the academic understanding of Chinese foreign policy. Broadly speaking, modern China's diplomatic history has conventionally been periodized with 6 key events acting as dividers, though different scholars vary in their interpretations of the relative importance of each.[6] The first of these events was the establishment of the PRC in 1949, which culminated in a period of initial isolation with little international recognition. During this period Chinese foreign policy largely followed Soviet policies, a policy described as the "leaning to one side strategy" by Mao.[7] The second period saw China begin pursuing a more autonomous foreign policy following the Geneva and Bandung conferences in 1954 and 1955, cementing a long-running identification with the emerging non-aligned movement within the global south.[8] The third period began when divergences with Moscow came to a head in the early 1960s with the Sino-Soviet split, relations reaching a nadir with border skirmishes in 1969 which brought the nations to the brink of war. Coinciding with the peak of the Maoist movement within the country, this period saw China actively seeking to match and counter Soviet Influence abroad while exporting Maoist revolution.[9]

A significant turning point occurred in the early 1970s, when China's international isolation was broken by the thaw in Sino-American relations and culminated in the 1979 normalization of relations; while internally the death of Mao and the purging of the gang of four in 1976 began the nation's gradual emergence from the cultural revolution.[10] The period beginning in the early 1980s saw a firmly post-revolutionary and rapidly developing China under Deng begin pursuing a policy of 'lying low', prioritizing pragmatic economic development and modernization.[11] This was replaced in the early 2010s with a more assertive approach corresponding with the elevation of Xi Jinping, categorized by high-profile initiatives and rising geopolitical tensions.

Despite these dramatic historical shifts, the national interests underlying the foreign policy of the PRC are generally regarded to be relatively consistent through time. Using Waltz's three-level international relations theory, Cai's 2022 survey identified seven major foreign policy objectives representing Beijing's core national interests. These are respectively

securing China's existing political system of one-party (CCP) rule;

maintaining state sovereignty;

safeguarding national security;

preserving territorial integrity;

achieving national reunification with Taiwan as well as gaining and maintaining control over territories like Hong Kong, Macau, Tibet and Xinjiang;

ensuring sustained economic development and modernization; and

restoring the nation's great power status and enhancing its international position.[12]

There is a similar consensus that China's diplomatic interests have expanded over time. Ye's 2019 article discussing China's national interest over time using a Neoclassical Realist-Based Analytical Framework[13] argues that as Chinese hard power increased, China's national interest expanded from the domestic to the regional level. More economically focused studies have echoed this sentiment, with Flint and Zhang's article using world-systems analysis to argue that changes in the world economic cycle have been a key contributor to the country's increasingly outgoing foreign policy.

While there is an overall consensus regarding the overall historiographical outline of China's foreign policy, there exists considerable divergences in the way the Chinese foreign policy has been interpreted in the West.[14] Theoretically, the different positions can broadly be broken down into realist, liberal and critical schools. The most common theoretical perspective employed, at least in studies on Chinese Middle Eastern policy, is that of offensive realism, though this is often implicit as these tend to be heavily empirical in focus. Mearsheimer's conception of great power politics as fundamentally one of zero-sum power maximization applies intuitively at a policy level to those writing within a policy environment where containing Chinese influence is often one underlying objective.[15] Consequently, studies conducted by Think Tanks, Western Governments and security studies researchers tend to assume that Chinese foreign policy is motivated by a desire to expand its hard power capabilities in both relative and absolute terms, though this should not be taken to necessarily imply a military-driven focus. The CSIS's ChinaPower project is a standout example of this line of research in which praxis is prioritized over theory and the means over the ends.[16]

Balanced against this approach is a growing body of liberal scholarship which generally considers Chinese foreign policy objectives as primarily economic. As an institutional approach that prioritizes the development of organizations, regimes and institutions as facilitators of communication and cooperation as opposed to conflict, liberal scholarship on Chinese foreign policy has tended to regard China since Reform and Opening Up in a more sympathetic light; particularly where trade is concerned. A key example of this line of thought was the many articles published in the late 2010s in response to then-US President Donald Trump's decision to impose tariffs on Chinese exports and the trade war that ensued, most of which criticized the policy on economic grounds as a lose-lose proposition.[17]

Within the various schools of thought that fall under the 'critical' label, post-colonial readings of Chinese Foreign policy are by far the most dominant, given the rise of scholarship from 'global south' based or focused institutions. This approach has been given a further boost in popularity in recent years as a result of various Chinese initiatives ranging from BRICs and the BRI, as well as various China forums such as the China-Arab States Cooperation Forum and the Forum on China-Africa Cooperation (FOCAC). Critical scholars tend to take a more normative approach when ascribing motivations to Chinese foreign policy, emphasising China's revisionist challenge to

the established norms of the liberal international order, particularly its consistent insistence on non-interventionism through the 'Five Principles'. [18]

In contrast with international research, Chinese scholarship regarding interpretations of Chinese foreign policy is seldom dedicated to any single driving theoretical approach. On the one hand, Chinese publications tend to ascribe more weight to China's official proclamations regarding its normative aspirations. China's ideological commitment to multipolarity, non-intervention and mutual benefit is regarded as sacrosanct, and in recent years occasionally accredited as essential components of Xi Jinping Thought.[19] These concerns are, however, treated more as broad directions than as concrete instructions. At the praxis level, Chinese scholars typically assume Chinese foreign policy to be pragmatic above all else, a phrase that within Chinese discourse may be understood as an explicit rejection of both the ideologically motivated foreign policy of the Maoist period and the liberal interventionism of the West.[20] This dichotomy between high-minded idealism and realism-esque realpolitik is not seen as contradictory and is often both employed within the same article.

In recent years, Chinese foreign policy towards the Middle East has seen a dramatic rise in academic interest corresponding with the country's increasing influence. This should, however, be caveated by the widely repeated understanding that the region has never been a top priority to Beijing, given its peripheral role to China's aforementioned core national interests. For instance, within the concentric circle model of Chinese security priorities described by Nathan and Scobell, the Middle East falls within the outermost circle, eclipsed by the inner three circles made up of Beijing's sovereign territory, countries bordering China on land and sea, and China's proximate regional orders such as Central Asia respectively.[21] Correspondingly, the periodization of PRC foreign policy in the region roughly tracks with that of Chinese foreign policy overall – Burton for example identifies three main periods: the revolutionary Maoist period from 1949-1970s, the period of pragmatic development and cultivation of commercial and diplomatic ties from the late 70s to the 2000s, and finally a rise in influence starting from 2010.[22]

Given the contending interpretations of China's foreign policy discussed above, different authors have unsurprisingly prioritized different aspects of China's interests in the Middle East. These narratives however tend to be overlapping rather than contradictory in nature within regional discussions, with **energy, economic development**, **geostrategy**, and **security** being generally accepted areas of concern. One commonly cited aspect of the country's interest in the region is the importance of Middle Eastern fossil fuels to its economy. The volume of Chinese imports has increased more than 45-fold since the country became a net importer in 1993, with the Middle East consistently supplying roughly half of the traffic.[23] Much of China's initiatives in the region have been interpreted as downstream effects of the hydrocarbon trade. China's direct and indirect military presence, for instance, can be interpreted as an insurance policy to guarantee its energy interests as the region's largest oil importer.[24] Since the 2010s, however, Beijing's economic interests in the region have clearly expanded beyond the energy sector, with the region increasingly being regarded as serving both as an investment and export destination for China.[25]

China's role as a great power in the region is recent and complicated by its contradictory reliance on the US-led security structure which some have derided as 'free riding'.[26] By positioning itself as a champion of non-interventionism and a mediator, China has achieved some success in its "March West" agenda, enjoying the noteworthy status of being the only major power to enjoy good relations with every player in the region.[27] One of the main benefits Beijing has reaped has been the

region's general acceptance of its Uighur policy, despite the potentially sympathetic cause of an oppressed Muslim population.[28]

In practice, China divides its diplomatic partnerships in the Middle East into several tiers, the highest being the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. Iran falls within this category, as does Egypt, Saudi Arabia, the UAE and Bahrain. Most other states in the region fall under the class below, that being the Strategic Partnership, while Israel exclusively has an Innovative Comprehensive Partnership agreement with Beijing.[29] At the multilateral level, institutions such as the China-Arab States Cooperation Forum (CASCF), BRICS and the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) provide the platforms through which ministerial-level meetings and sub-ministerial-level working groups are held.

2.2: Fanatic Pragmatism: The Logic of Iranian Foreign Policy

Although the history of the modern Islamic Republic of Iran began in 1979, from the start its foreign policy enjoyed considerable continuity with those of the Shah's. In 1953, a CIA-sponsored coup overthrew the reformist Prime Minister Muhammad Musaddiq and placed the Shah in power to prevent the nationalization of oil and gas. While pro-Western, the Shah's regime was far from a passive puppet regime. One of Imperial Iran's primary policy objectives was securing regional hegemony, and it actively courted the world's powers great and small in pursuit of that goal.[30] From the standpoint of regional security, Tehran's two main threats at this time were the Soviet Union and Iraq, both of which had significant direct borders with Iran. In the late 1970s, this threat was heightened by events in Afghanistan where an army coup had led to Soviet military intervention. In 1979, a series of cascading events led to the collapse of the Iranian Imperial Regime and the creation of the Islamic Republic of Iran. The early years of the Islamic Republic were marred by conflict and uncertainty, with the Tehran hostage crisis and internal infighting between various revolutionary factions starting almost as soon as the Shah's exile. These events coupled with the Iraqi invasion in 1980 saw Iran reach a nadir of vulnerability and isolation.[31]

There is a broad consensus among academic studies of Iranian foreign policy that there has been considerable continuity in the tactics and aims of the Islamic Republic since the mid-1980s.[32] Unlike China researchers, modern scholars on Iran tend to be more comfortable with simultaneously presenting multiple perspectives and motivations without assigning primacy to any single perspective. While individual studies borrow from different schools of thought, the actual conduct of analysis is commonly in the style of Foreign Policy Analysis and focus on the specifics of foreign policy formulation. Given its hostile environs, immediate regime survival is generally regarded as the implicit motivator of many of the Republic's decisions, and consequently has determined the themes on which the existing literature has focused.

Regional ambitions

Since its earliest days, the Islamic Republic has faced no shortage of regional threats, ranging in severity from existential (e.g. Baathist Iraq) to adversarial (Saudi Arabia). Against these threats, Iran has consistently sought buffers through proxies which serve to create strategic depth while providing flexibility.[33] In Iraq, Lebanon and Yemen, Tehran has constructed a powerful 'axis of resistance' by strategically leveraging sectarianism amidst political turmoil.[34] When dealing with more stable neighbours, Iran pursues a highly pragmatic approach, a notable example being its support for Armenia over fellow Shiite power Azerbaijan, as well as its demonstrated willingness to abandon even closely aligned Islamist movements when they prove inconvenient.[35]

Deterrence

Given the array of powerful external threats which confront Tehran, asymmetric deterrence has long been one of the regime's central strategic priorities. While the Iranian Nuclear program is by far the most significant of these initiatives,[36] Iran has also been willing to leverage the use of terrorism to achieve disproportionate strategic impacts with limited resources. The bombing campaign against Paris in 1986, for instance, is widely regarded to have been organized by Iran with the dual aims of deterring arms sales to Iraq and encouraging the return of debt and enriched Uranium owed as part of Iran's Eurodif investment; a similar campaign was conducted against Argentina in the early 1990s.[37]

Ideology

The ideology of the Islamic Republic is often oversimplified to merely that of Shiite religious fanaticism in popular understanding; and while Islamism and the closely linked ideas of Khomeini are central tenets of Iran's strategic outlook, this often obscures the more sophisticated synthesis of ideals that characterize Iranian politics.[38] The Iranian revolution was not only carried out by the religiously motivated, but also by various left-wing groups opposing the Shah for political reasons. While these groups were largely purged in the power struggles after the revolution, their ideology was partially co-opted by the Islamic regime. In particular, anti-colonialism and Third-Worldism remain prominent in the modern Iranian political discourse.[39] The significance of secular Iranian nationalism should also not be underrated, particularly in the context of the Iran-Iraq War. While there is some debate over the relative balance between Islamic idealism and realist national considerations, the question is merely one of degree.

Regime Politics

Iranian foreign policy is commonly seen as reflecting internal political shifts between various factions. The Ayatollah Khamenei, supreme leader since 1989, has generally been understood as a hard-liner.[40] The Islamic Revolutionary Guard's Corps (IRGC) and its associated institutions such as the Martyrs Foundation have been associated with political radicalism and militarization.[41] Figures such as Rouhani have in contrast been interpreted as moderates pushing for a pragmatic line in foreign affairs, and for a greater prioritization of economic development.[42]

2.3: Words Louder than Actions: Interpretations of Sino-Iranian Relations

Studies on Sino-Iranian Relations can broadly be divided into four categories: histories of Sino-Iranian Relations, Western articles on Sino-Iranian Relations, Chinese articles on Sino-Iranian Relations and Iranian articles on Sino-Iranian Relations. Among these myriad works, Garver's *China and Iran: Ancient Partners in a Post-imperial World* merits special mention as the most comprehensive book-length historical survey of bilateral relations between China and Iran.[43] In terms of theory, Garver's work is also distinct in terms of its emphasis on the concept of civilizations. While superficially resembling Huntington's famous "clash of civilizations" thesis then in vogue in the West, Garver's argument is primarily based on shared historical experiences between China and Iran rather than similarities in culture. In essence, the shared experience of being ancient great civilizations recently oppressed by Western imperialism allows for a unique groundswell of friendly sentiment between the two nations. While Garver's book remains the go-to source for historical background on Sino-Iranian Relations, it is now complemented by newer works on the topic. Azad's 2017 I*ran and China: A new approach to their bilateral relations* is particularly valuable in two respects: the author's insights into the role of North Korea as a facilitator, as well as the deliberate intent to avoid rehashing old ground within the passage.[44]

The main academic debate surrounding China-Iran relations lies in the depth of Sino-Iranian Ties: to what extent is either party willing to commit to the other? Given the disparity in geopolitical weight between China and Iran, as well as the latter's international isolation, the ball is firmly in China's court.[45] There exists a strong trend in Western scholarship towards dismissing Sino-Iranian relations as much beyond a partnership on convenience. Garver, for instance, criticized China of playing a double game with Washington regarding nuclear-related sanctions; a statement that would apply equally to China's relationship with Iran.[46] A 2010 roundtable of experts reached a similar conclusion regarding, dismissing the Sino-Relationship as merely "fair-weather business partners."[47] Studies focusing on Chinese arms exports to Iran came to similar conclusions.[48] Even more recent studies published following supposed upgrades Sino-Iranian ties raised concerns regarding whether China's commitment towards Iran could withstand significant pressure.[49]

The outlook becomes even more pessimistic when scholarship focusing on China's regional policy is brought in. Temiz's 2021 book-length overview on China's Middle Eastern Policy puts forward the broad consensus that China's policy of non-alignment leads it to pursue a policy of regional balancing.[50] This understanding is mirrored by other regional surveys of Chinese policy, which argue that Chinese ties with Iran only constitute a relatively minor part of Chinese regional foreign policy. Iranian-Saudi relations are a case in point: while China was willing to broker a deal in 2023, China had previously been just as willing to supply both belligerents with arms up to and including cruise missiles.[51]

The 2013 book *Modern Relations between China and Iran* is the most comprehensive work on Sino-Iranian relations in Chinese, with the authors taking a methodical if unspectacular approach to cataloguing various aspects of Sino-Iranian Relations.[52] Interestingly, Chinese publications on Sino-Iranian relations tend to call for caution when approaching important issues. An article published by the former Chinese ambassador to Iran for instance called for a gradual expansion of Chinese influence in addressing the Iranian nuclear crisis, though not in explicit opposition to the West.[53] Similarly, a study using quantitative methods found that America remains far more significant to Iran than China.[54]

Relatively few Iranian sources on Sino-Iranian relations have been translated into English at the moment (for the purposes of the 'Iranian Perspective' Iranian scholars working overseas will be omitted.) What little is translated betrays a degree of Iranian frustration that China often fails to prioritize Iran, and occasionally even participates in the international sanctions regime.[55] The failure of Iran's 2005 Look to the East Policy is a clear indicator of the limits to Sino-Iranian cooperation.

III: Drivers of Sino-Iranian Relations

3.1: Different Beds, Shared Dreams: The Ideological Aspect of Sino-Iranian RelationsGiven the divergent interests between China and Iran, their cooperation has unsurprisingly been concentrated within a few areas of mutual interest. The most apparent of these are the three ideological strains driving the two together, largely derived from commonalities in their history. The first of these is the aforementioned civilizational Silk Road connection. As Figueroa recent historical research demonstrates, these connections both predate the Iranian Revolution and extend beyond the state level. While officially, China actively courted the Shah's government culminating in Hua Guofeng's 1978 visit, the PRC was simultaneously indirectly backing Iranian Maoist groups. Even at this early date, both sides deliberately cultivated Silk Road discourse as a means to counter their political differences.[56] This ideological theme continues well past the revolution: in 1991, Chinese President Yang Shangkun would make a point of the "two thousand years of friendly exchanges" between two peoples;" sentiments echoed a decade later by Iranian President Khatami when he spoke of the countries as being "cradles of two great civilizations." [57]

As two ostensibly post-revolutionary regimes, the PRC and IRI maintain a shared defensive interest in opposing Western influence within their respective regions. As with their civilizational connection, this is an area of long-term continuity, extending to before the revolution. Historically, China's 'Century of Humiliation' echoes Iran's exploitation by imperial powers such as Britain and Russia during the 'Great Game,' and both have consequently embraced a fundamentally revisionist view of history with a long list of wrongs to be righted. A shared wariness of what both countries perceived to be first Soviet and then American hegemonism played a role in both Sino-Iranian Rapprochements during the 1960s and 80s, given their mutual opposition to the Cold War bipolar paradigm.[58] Both governments perceived the US-led liberal world order during and after the Unipolar moment in the 90s as a significant hegemonic threat, countering humanitarian and pro-democracy rhetoric with shared commitments to non-interventionism and the primacy of state sovereignty. One example is the backing Tehran has provided Beijing's whenever criticism of its policies in Xinjiang and Hong Kong has arisen.[59] On a more proactive front, Iran and China share an interest in establishing a more multilateral world order by replacing existing Western-led institutions. This has primarily manifested institutionally in their mutual membership in groups such as the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) and BRICs, as well as normatively through rhetorical alignment in theatres such as the United Nations.[60]

3.2: Choppy Seas, Heavy Water: Security and Sino-Iranian Relations

Often described as the crosswords of Eurasia, the territory of Iran has long been a prized possession of Empires both domestic and foreign. Throughout history, the land has drawn invaders from far and wide, from the ancient Hittites to the Medieval Mongols. In modern times, the overthrow of Mossadeq by a CIA-backed coup in 1953 drew the country firmly into the US alliance system, yet threats from domestic, regional and global powers persisted.[61] China's position during the early Cold War was similarly insecure: the Sino-Soviet split in 1961 meant the newly formed People's Republic was faced with hostile relations from both the Capitalist and Communist blocs, tensions which almost led to war in 1969. These pressures, together with the gradual de-prioritizing of Iran by the United States following rapprochement with the USSR began drawing the two nations together, culminating in Beijing's abandonment of the Popular Front for the Liberation of Oman (PFLO) and the normalization of relations in 1971.[62]

As a result of the friendly relations enjoyed between the Shah and the People's Republic, the revolutionary Iranian government initially saw China as a security threat to be contained, a situation

worsened by the untimely nature of Hua Guofeng's 1978 visit in the midst of protests.[63] China's close relations with the United States at this time was similarly a bone of contention. This awkward situation did not last long: in 1980, Saddam's Iraq launched a brutal invasion of the nascent Islamic Republic, sending its disorganized forces reeling back in disarray. To make matters worse, the international sanctions imposed by the US following the Tehran hostage crisis ensured Iran would remain on the back foot in comparison with its Iraqi adversary, which could acquire plentiful and modern weapons through normal channels. Iran was essentially stuck with second-tier equipment from unscrupulous supplier seeking commercial advantage, the most important of which was China.[64]

In the 1980s, the PRC was in still the earliest stages of economic reform and perceived that the immediate revenue which arms sales generated outweighed the strategic disadvantages they potentially brought. Iran was a particularly attractive client in this regard, thanks to its ability to pay either in hard currency or oil shipments. China sold arms both directly to Tehran as well as indirectly through North Korea and Hong Kong, with deliveries remaining high well after the end of the war.[65] Only into the 90s did China gradually lose its advantage in comparison to the Former Soviet States, which had both large stockpiles of more advanced equipment and an urgent need for foreign currency to prop up their struggling economies.

One of the most significant aspects within Sino-Iranian Relations has been that of missile systems and technologies. In 1986, China supplied Iran with the infamous CSSC-2 Silkworm antiship missile batteries, the use of which significantly escalated tensions within the Persian Gulf during the Tanker War. This was followed in 1987 by the sale of SAM-2 and SAM-3 batteries to offset Iran's increasing weakness in aviation compared with Iraq.[66] During the 1990s, China began providing Iran with more advanced systems and capabilities, allegedly helping Iran set up production lines for the M-9 (DF-15/CSS-6) and M-11 missiles (DF-11/CSS7) at Esfahan;[67] as well as supplying then top-or-the-line C-801 and C-802 anti-ship missiles (roughly analogous to the Exocet).[68]

In 1985, China signed a secret nuclear cooperation agreement with Iran, with similar objectives of gaining commercial benefit from its extensive military nuclear capabilities while strengthening its relations with an aligned partner. China would supply four teaching and research reactors and fissile material for the cores, as well as providing training for Iranian engineers and scientists in the PRC. This was followed up by a publicly announced agreement in 1990 and the acknowledgement of specific details in 1991: Beijing admitted to providing a 27 kilowatt thermal (kWt) miniature neutron source reactor (MNSR) as well as a small calutron, an electromagnetic isotope separation (EMIS) device.[69] China responded to criticism by defending its nuclear cooperation as non-military in nature. A 1992 inspection from the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) found the EMIS devise to be too small to be of concern by itself, despite the use of similar technology in Iran's large-scale nuclear enrichment efforts.[70]

Yet from its inception, several factors gradually began to work against Sino-Iranian nuclear collaboration. Since its accession to the IAEA in 1984, Beijing had publicly pledged commitment to the organization's safeguards. Perhaps more significantly, China's civil nuclear power ambitions resulted in discussions with the United States to conclude a nuclear cooperation agreement (NCA) in which China's loose nuclear export policy became a sticking point. This would be signed in July 1985 following further Chinese commitments.[71] China's signing of the Non-Proliferation Treaty in 1992 was soon followed by a series of concessions to US Pressure. In September, China announced it would not sell a 27 MW nuclear reactor due to "technical difficulties", amidst speculation

regarding a controversial vote in Congress on most-favoured nation status and Bush's decision to sell F-16s to Taiwan.[72] A major turning point came in 1996-97 when negotiations preceding a prospective visit to the US saw China agree to demands to halt its nuclear cooperation with Iran and implement strict safeguards for both nuclear and dual-use goods.[73]Since then, Chinese support for Iran's nuclear program has dropped off significantly, with only vague references occasionally being made to 'private and state-owned entities' engaging in unspecified 'WMD-related Proliferation Activities.[74]

Since the early 2000s, Chinese arms sales began dropping off significantly for a range of reasons. While many have suggested Iran serves China by diverting American attention away from the Asia Pacific, the previous two decades suggests that China is largely unwilling to sacrifice its relations with the US and the West in general in support of Iran. China has largely complied with the UN sanctions and Embargo regimes against Tehran, with arms flows decreasing significantly since 2006 and with little sign of resurgence despite their expiration in 2020.[75] What little activity has taken place has largely been in small volumes through front companies.[76]

3.3: Oil Finds its Level: Economic Relations Between China and Iran

The underlying logic driving Sino-Iranian economic relations is simple. Since China became a net oil importer in the 1990s, the two countries have had highly complementary economic structures. Indeed, most scholarship considers economic ties to be the primary driver within Sino-Iranian Relations following the end of the Iran-Iraq War. China is currently the leading destination of Iran's oil exports, while Iran has consistently been among the PRC's top three energy suppliers. Even in 2011, before the imposition of sanctions, China was the single largest importer of Iranian oil, second only to the EU as a whole.[77] Early Chinese investments in Iran naturally focused on the energy sector, beginning in 2000 when China National Petroleum Corp (CNPC) and China Petroleum and Chemical Corp (Sinopec) began conducting oil exploration and development in the country. By 2007, a combination of US pressure driving away potential competitors and a more outgoing Chinese Policy saw these two companies acquire the contracts to develop Azadegan and Yadavaran oil fields respectively.

Before long, Chinese investors were moving into Iran's ailing downstream sectors, beginning with a 2009 contract to construct seven refineries as well as trans-Iran pipeline.[78] Chinese firms have built or financed major Iranian projects like the Tehran metro, highways, and upgrades to the port of Bandar Abbas.[79] Some scholars have described this mutual interdependency as a cycle in which Iran depends on Chinese purchases to sustain its economy while China benefits from the low cost and reliable flow of hydrocarbons to fuel its rapid development.[80] As an additional benefit, Iran's relatively large population of 85 million provides a consumer market with little competition to Chinese companies, which have consequently become major suppliers in sectors as diverse as power generation, mining and transportation equipment, as well as consumer goods such as electronics, auto parts, and toys.[81] This has not been without conflict – the flood of Chinese goods has led to both complaints about their quality and protests regarding their supposed low quality.[82] Nevertheless, in 2021 these economic ties culminated in the 25-year Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (CSP) agreement where China offered $400 billion in potential investments in exchange for a supply of more than a million barrels per day of heavily discounted Iranian oil.[83]

Beyond their direct bilateral ties, China and Iran have demonstrated a shared desire to reshape the global economic architecture. Blocked from Western financial systems such as SWIFT, Iran has instead actively chosen to participate in Chinese initiatives such as the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) and BRICS. Yet despite their joint rhetorical hostility towards Western

hegemonism, China has been cautious where Western Sanctions have been concerned. From 2006 to 2010, China supported four rounds of sanctions against Iran at the UNSC while simultaneously objecting in principle and seeking to 'delegitimise the approach towards sanctions adopted by the US and its allies by depicting it as an imperialist and interventionist.'[84] China actively contributed to the negotiation of the JCPoA, and following the breakdown of the nuclear deal in 2017 under the administration of Donald Trump ostensibly decreased its imports of Iranian Oil to between USD 200 million and zero. In practice, however, China continued to import a significant quantity of Iranian Oil through third countries such as Malaysia.[85] This policy of hedging and managing conflict has allowed China to maximize its economic and political benefits, at considerable political and literal expense to its ostensible Iranian partner.

IV: Unshared Adversaries

4.1: Friend to all, friend of none: Zero-sum Assumptions

If China and Iran seem like natural partners on paper, in practice their relationship is marked by caution, hedging, and an absence of formal alliance. The most striking way this manifests is in the way both states have pursued and maintained cooperative ties with each other's adversaries. The People's Republic of China has maintained close partnerships with Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, and even Israel, states whose relations with the Islamic Republic are at best lukewarm. Despite its weaker position, Iran too has not completely abandoned ties with actors at odds with Beijing, particularly Taiwan.

The question may fairly be raised as to why this phenomenon is noteworthy. In this, the case of Greece and Turkey is particularly instructive. Despite both being members of NATO since the early 1950s, tensions between the two countries have remained high; to the extent that both have maintained significantly higher relative defence spending than the alliance's average. Ironically, it is this very fact that their primary threat is intra-institutional that has prevented Greece and Turkey from being able to rely on the defensive umbrella provided by the alliance to guarantee their security.[86]

Given the imbalance of power within the Sino-Iranian Relationship dynamic, as well as the large array of hostile political actors faced by Tehran; Iran is far more exposed to the consequences of Chinese alignment with its adversaries than vice versa.[87] This was most painfully demonstrated during the Iran-Iraq War, when Chinese arms supplied to Iraq were directly employed against the Iranians. Thus, although the case of Iran's lukewarm partnership with Taiwan will be examined, the main focus of this and the next section will remain on the implications of China's close relations with Iran's regional rivals.

One important theoretical point worth addressing is to what extent the situation faced by Iran vis a vis its adversaries may be considered zero-sum, given the underlying logical assumption of 'one's gain is another's loss' required. In general, the more securitized and anarchic the international context, the closer it is aligned with zero-sum models of competition. This phenomenon is well-illustrated by the foundational texts of realism: Herz's 1950 security dilemma is for instance focused on the intense bipolar competition of the early Cold War,[88] while Waltz uses the example of multipolar Europe as a securitized, anarchic society.[89] Similarly, Wendt using a constructivist approach argues that only within a Hobbesian anarchy in which the culture is one of 'all against all' is competition a zero-sum affair.[90] Contrast this with the liberal institutional approach of scholars

like Keohone, whose focus is on international institutions and their role in facilitating information exchange and reducing transaction costs in order to attain absolute gain.[91]

Several factors work in favour of the applicability of the anarchic zero-sum model within the context of Iran and its neighbours. The first is the high insecurity the Persian Gulf and the Middle East more generally has suffered from in the past half century, with both large-scale conventional wars such as the three Gulf wars, long-running proxy conflicts and everything in between. The second is the lack of well-established alliance structures and corresponding institutions within the region: while regional organizations such as the Gulf Cooperation Council and Arab League do exist, they fail to provide the security guarantees that formal alliances such as NATO guarantee. The third is that the region has no shortage of 'middle powers', with Saudi Arabia, Iran, Turkey, Egypt and formerly Iran all having some claim to being 'regional powers.' A fourth contributing factor is that thanks to the dominance of the energy sector, most of the region's trade is conducted externally, reducing incentives for intra-regional cooperation. The final factor is arguably the nature and history of the Islamic Republic itself: as a non-Arab, Islamic Republic in a region dominated by Western-aligned Arab monarchies and formerly secular Arab governments, the IRI was somewhat of a regional pariah from its inception; a fact painfully illustrated by its isolation in 1980 when the Arab governments almost universally aligned with the Iraqi invaders.[92]

4.2: Love-Hate Triangle: China, Iran and Saudi Arabia

The rivalry between Saudi Arabia and Iran has often been described as a regional cold war. Since the Iranian revolution, the rivalry between the two has been intractable and multifaceted. Both seek regional leadership: Saudi Arabia defends the region's established Arab powers; Iran seeks to upend its isolation through a series of proxies. Both are on opposite sides of the sectarian divide: Iran as the leading Shiite power, Saudi Arabia as the defender of the Sunni faith. To Iran, Saudi Arabia's pro-American stance further threatens to strengthen the American and Western interventionist threat on its doorstep.[93]

Consequently, the two powers have been at significant odds since the 1980s. Saudi Arabia was a key financier and backer of Saddam's invasion against Iran. In Yemen, Iran's close ties with South Yemen would eventually transition into its backing for the Houthi insurgency in the early 2000s against the Saudi-backed united Yemeni government. Saudi Arabia and Iran sponsor competing factions in Iraq, Lebanon and Syria, in each seeking to expand their influence at the expense of their rival.[94]

Since the Iran-Iraq War, Saudi Arabia and Iran have been locked in a regional arms race, with a heavy focus on ballistic missile competition with potential nuclear implications. Both have sought to acquire both offensive mid to long-range delivery systems as well as defensive interceptors, with Saudi Arabia being a major user of the Patriot system. Since the mid-2000s, the Saudis have proactively developed civil nuclear technology programs which many consider to be in response to Iran's nuclear ambitions.[95]

Since their normalization of relations in 1990, relations between Beijing and Riyadh have developed rapidly to the extent that some have argued they exceed those between Beijing and Tehran. Like Sino-Iranian relations, Sino-Saudi ties are driven by the energy sector. China's oil imports from Saudi Arabia have generally exceeded those from Iran significantly, with Saudi Arabia being China's single largest energy supplier. Similarly, China has become a significant investor in downstream sectors of the Saudi economy and a major exporter of consumer goods in the Saudi market, particularly in the infrastructure sector.[96]

Politically, Saudi Arabia and China are aligned in a joint desire for South-South collaboration and multilateralism, as well as in ideological opposition to Western liberalism. China refrained from commenting on the October 2018 Khashoggi affair, while Saudi Arabia's support for China's position on issues related to Taiwan, Hong Kong (one-China policy), and Xinjiang have remained consistent.[97] Saudi Arabia welcomed the Belt and Road initiative in 2013 and was a founding member of the AIIB in 2014, and China has regarded it as a top-tier comprehensive strategic partner since 2016.[98] Unlike with Iran, Sino-Saudi relations have not been actively countered by the US, with Washington even secretly helping to facilitate deals such as the 2007 Chinese sale of DF-21 missiles.[99]

Security cooperation between China and Saudi Arabia are limited but highly focused, concentrating on the provision of UAVs and missile capabilities, as well as satellite intelligence cooperation. Notably, the two would reach an agreement for localized production of the CH-4 Caihong UAV in Saudi Arabia. While the absolute volume of these transfers remains small, they grant high-end capabilities that allow the Saudis to asymmetrically counter both Iran's missile programs and proxy groups.[100]

China's balancing position between Saudi Arabia and Iran was starkly demonstrated in 2023, when it brokered a Saudi-Iran détente restoring diplomatic relations between the two after a seven-year rupture. While this alleviated tensions in the region, Saudi-Iran relations are still clouded by considerable mistrust and suspicion – a situation made more dangerous by the outbreak of war in Gaza and the activities of the Houthis.[101]

4.3: Persian Gulf, Emirati Flagship: China, Iran and the UAE

Over the past decades, Iran and the UAE have been embroiled in an intractable conflict over control of the Islands of the Persian Gulf. Since 1971, The UAE has accused Iran of illegally occupying the Greater Tunb, Lesser Tunb, Abu Musa islands as well as three smaller islands it claims, for its part Iran the Emirates of occupying its Ariana and Zarkooh Islands. These islands collectively straddle the straits of Hormuz and are consequently of vital strategic significance to Iran. Iran's militarisation of the Islands during the Iran-Iraq war and 2020 decision to settle the three larger Islands with Iranian citizens have inflamed tensions, though the UAE has thus far refrained from responding with direct force.[102]

Beyond their territorial dispute, several factors have contributed to the mistrust between the UAE and Iran. The UAE's close alignment with Saudi Arabia through the GCC has brought it into conflict with Iran over Yemen, with Adu Dhabi deploying troops in support of Riyadh's intervention from 2015-19.[103] Like Saudi Arabia, the UAE is aligned with the United States and plays host to American and French forces. The UAE has adhered to sanctions against Iran following the US withdrawal from the Iran nuclear deal, and accepted normalization of relations with Israel in 2020; both actions which inflamed tensions with Tehran.[104]

The development of Chinese relations with the UAE follows the familiar pattern from oil imports to multilateral cooperation and heavily resembles that of Sino-Saudi relations. China's oil imports from the UAE have been significant, making up around 3% of its overall imports. To China, the UAE's political stability and business-friendly policies have made it a particularly favoured investment and export destination. In 2019, Chinese direct investment in the Emirates would account for more than half of its total investment in the Arab League, making the country by far Beijing's most dominant regional partner in this regard. The UAE is also China's largest regional

trade partner in non-energy sectors, as it acts as an entrepot for the re-export of Chinese goods into Africa and Europe.[105]

Politically, China and the UAE share several interests. Both were threatened in 2012 by the potential for religiously motivated unrest following the Arab Spring. Both are in ideological opposition to liberal interventionism and support a range of other global-South positions on topics such as climate change and UN reform. The UAE supports China's positions on Taiwan,

Hong Kong, and Xinjiang, and China supports the UAE's position in Yemen.[106] As a result, the UAE has been an important participant in many of China's political initiatives such as Belt and Road and the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank. In 2012, a strategic partnership was announced by the two countries, which was upgraded to the highest tier of Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in 2019 following a visit by Xi Jinping.[107] The UAE's security relationship with China is similar to that with Saudi Arabia, small in quantity but focused on high-end satellite, drone and intelligence capabilities.[108] In 2024 notably joined an Arab League–UAE statement supporting Emirati claims on Abu Musa and the Tunbs against Iran.[109]

4.4: Between sworn enemies: China, Iran and Israel

The hostility between Israel and Iran has been one of the major drivers of conflict in the region since the Islamic Revolution, with the two often regarded as being in a state of continuous proxy war. In marked contrast to the Shah's regime, which enjoyed close ties with Israel, the 1979 Islamic Revolution brought to power a new regime which espoused an Islamist, anti-Zionist agenda. The Ayatollah Khomeini unilaterally terminated relations with Tel Aviv, turning over the ex-Israeli embassy in Tehran to the PLO as a sign of the new government's commitment to champion the Palestinian Cause. Israel was branded as the driving force of Imperialism in the region, the "Little Satan", a 'source of corruption which has settled in the heart of the Islamic lands under the patronage of the superpowers 'which should be eliminated through the efforts of Islamic countries.[110]While residue ties and the mutual threat of Iraq saw Israel transfer some $500 million worth of spare parts for American equipment to Iran, the end of the war saw this connection completely severed.

There are several major dimensions to the Iran-Israeli conflict. The first is Iran's support for anti-Israel groups across the Middle East, from the Houthis in Yemen to Hezbollah in Lebanon and Hamas in Gaza amongst others. The regime of Bashar Al-Assad in Syria has similarly been often considered part of this 'axis of resistance'. This network of proxies has allowed Iran to sustain a continuous armed struggle against Israel, while asymmetrically limiting its exposure to direct military retaliation.[111]

Iran's nuclear program is regarded as an existential threat within the Israeli establishment and has consequently been the focus of tit-for-tat sabotage and espionage. Most famously, the high-profile Israeli-American Stuxnet attack in 2010 was an early illustration of both the potential of modern cyber warfare and Israel's determination to counter Iran's nuclear ambitions.[112] In the same year, the Mossad conducted a series of assassinations against Iran's nuclear scientists.[113] Iran's alleged response to these attacks was to attempt bombings against Israeli embassies worldwide, though with little success.[114]

Diplomatically, Israel and Iran have consistently sought to undermine and isolate each other's positions. Israel strongly objected to the 2015 Iran nuclear deal, arguing that it would be unable to effectively restrict Iranian nuclear development while providing Iran with funds to support terrorism.[115] Iran for its part has vehemently opposed normalization between Israel and Arab states,

with Ali Khamenei stating that Arab nations that have normalized relations with Israel have "sinned" by abandoning occupied Jerusalem and the Palestinians and should reverse their decision.[116]

China's relations with Israel differ significantly from those it maintains with other Middle Eastern Powers for a myriad of factors. Politically, Israel is far more aligned with the West than with the Global South and is often viewed through postcolonial lens by Beijing.[117] Nevertheless, this has not prevented the two nations for developing close commercial ties, nor pursuing security relations where reasonable.

In 2017, China and Israel announced the formation of an Innovative Comprehensive partnership, a label reflecting both Israel's unique economic position and Chinese respect for regional sensitivities. Economically, Israel's hi-tech innovation sector has been attractive to Chinese investors, with giants Xiaomi and Alibaba setting up R&D centres in the country; this technological cooperation extending to the Academic sector when in 2017 the Israel Institute of Technology set up a satellite campus in Guangdong. Israel has pronounced its support for the BRI, with Chinese firms actively supporting Israeli infrastructure projects up to and including a 25-year grant to the Shanghai International Port Group to operate the Northern port in Haifa.[118]

Historically, Israel provided vital support to China's military modernization efforts during the 1980s, transferring both weapon systems such as the Python-3 air-to-air missile, the MAPATZ anti-tank missile as well as technologies for projects such as the Chinese indigenous J-10 fighter plane. Only under heavy US pressure were military transfers curtailed in the early 2000s.[119]

4.5: Money has no smell: China and the Iran-Iraq War

In 1980, Saddam launched what he hoped to be a limited pre-emptive strike against Iran, hoping to resolve the Shatt al-Arab dispute, trigger an uprising in the Khuzestan area, and deter and weaken the aggressive elements of the newly formed Islamist regime.[120] Instead, the invasion had the opposite effect of uniting the Iranian people against the intruders despite initial disarray, with resistance coalescing around the city of Khorramshahr. Despite the city's eventual fall, the 34-day battle against fanatical Iranian resistance exhausted Iraqi offensive momentum, paving the way for a series of successful Iranian counterattacks in 1981 and 1982.[121] Now dominated by hawkish leaders such as Akbar Rafsanjani and Ali Khamenei, Iran launched continuous attacks over the next 6 years against increasingly fortified Iraqi positions in battles reminiscent of the First World War; a metaphor made particularly fitting by the large-scale employment of poison gas by Iraqi forces and the severity of Iranian casualties. Only in 1988 did the cumulative effects of Iran's political and economic isolation allow Iraq to build up a significant material advantage, which it converted into a ceasefire through a series of decisive military victories.[122]

Despite its rhetoric against the war and foreign involvement, Beijing saw the war as an opportunity to reap considerable profit and shipped dramatic quantities of equipment to both sides.[123] In total, Chinese shipments to Iraq are estimated to have been worth USD 6 billion in 1988 dollars, making up approximately 8% of total foreign arms delivered to the country during the war. This included 1,500 T-59/T-69 tanks and 300 Type-59 towed field guns (beginning in 1981), CSSC-2 Silkworm antiship missile batteries (in 1982), 30 F-7 fighters (from 1983 to 1985), 4 H-6 bombers (in 1988), as well as several tens of thousands of light weapons and several million various shells and munitions.[124]

China's direct transfers to Iran during the war totalled an estimated USD 3 billion in 1988 dollars in value, making up around 12.5% of the Iranian import total. This included 200 T-59/T-69 tanks and

80 F-6/F-7 fighters; CSSC-2 Silkworm antiship missile batteries (in 1986); SAM-2 and SAM-3 batteries (in 1987); 10 CAT-14 light patrol boats; 1,000 mortars; millions of various shells, mines, and munitions; as well as several tens of thousands of light weapons. China also offered less quantifiable assistance in the form of refurbishing captured Soviet-style equipment and training assistance for the IRGC in China.[125] The case for Iran is further complicated by the US sanctions imposed against Tehran, which meant a large portion of Chinese origin materiel was redirected through North Korea, including an USD 1.3 billion contract in 1983 and an USD 1 billion contract in 1984.[126] North Korean transfers totalled USD 3 billion, and together with direct Chinese supplies made up a quarter of all deliveries received by Iran during the war.[127]

Overall, Chinese direct and indirect supplies to Iran were arguably essential in sustaining the Islamic Republic's war effort. Though less valuable than its deliveries to Iraq, China's willingness to bypass US sanctions made it a far more significant source of weapons to Tehran than Baghdad. Whether on balance, China's involvement in the Iran-Iraq War may be considered genuine assistance to the beleaguered Iranian population is best left to the reader's judgement.

V: Action and Words: Quantifying the Relative Priority of Sino-Iranian Relations

5.1: Quantifying the Sino-Iranian Security Relationship

Given the complexity and potential variations within security interactions between States, any metric will of necessity only partially cover part of the security dynamic. Nonetheless, when comparing the relative significance of the Sino-Iranian Security Relationship with that between China and its regional rivals, several factors suggest the applicability of arms transfer data as a baseline. The most fundamental of these is the fact that, as the previous sections demonstrate, China's security relations with the Middle East have been primarily transactional, lacking both the permanent direct presence and alliance structures which categorize American security relations with the region. Thus, arms transfers are by far the most dominant and influential aspect in which China has made an impact on regional security dynamics. A second significant factor is the intense competition between Iran and its neighbours, the zero-sum assumptions of which support the inference that any arms transferred to the region would, at the very least, move the needle on the balance of power between them. Finally, China's approach to security cooperation with the region has been demonstrably consistent across states, reducing the extent to which other factors may complicate any analysis.[128]

Currently, the most comprehensive open-source database available is SIPRI's Arms Transfer Database, which aims to track all transfers of major conventional arms from 1950 to the most recent full calendar year, as well as licensed production which SIPRI defines as "a range of activities whereby the recipient is granted permission to produce major conventional weapons from kits or blueprints provided by a foreign supplier".[129] Given the longer-term focus of this study, SIPRI's trend-indicator value (TIV) is the most applicable metric, as it measures the military capability of transferred items as opposed to their financial value so that the pricing system remains consistent across weapons systems and periods; and employs 5-year moving averages to provide a more stable measure for trends. As TIV is calculated primarily based on the known unit production costs of a core set of weapons, it is ideal for our intended purpose of evaluating the value of deliveries as a measure of China's relative priorities between Iran and its adversaries.[130] Note that the data for this section is pulled from SIPRI's Arms transfers database, accessed 31st April 2025 at

https://armstransfers.sipri.org/ArmsTransfer/, and may consequently differ from past and future studies.

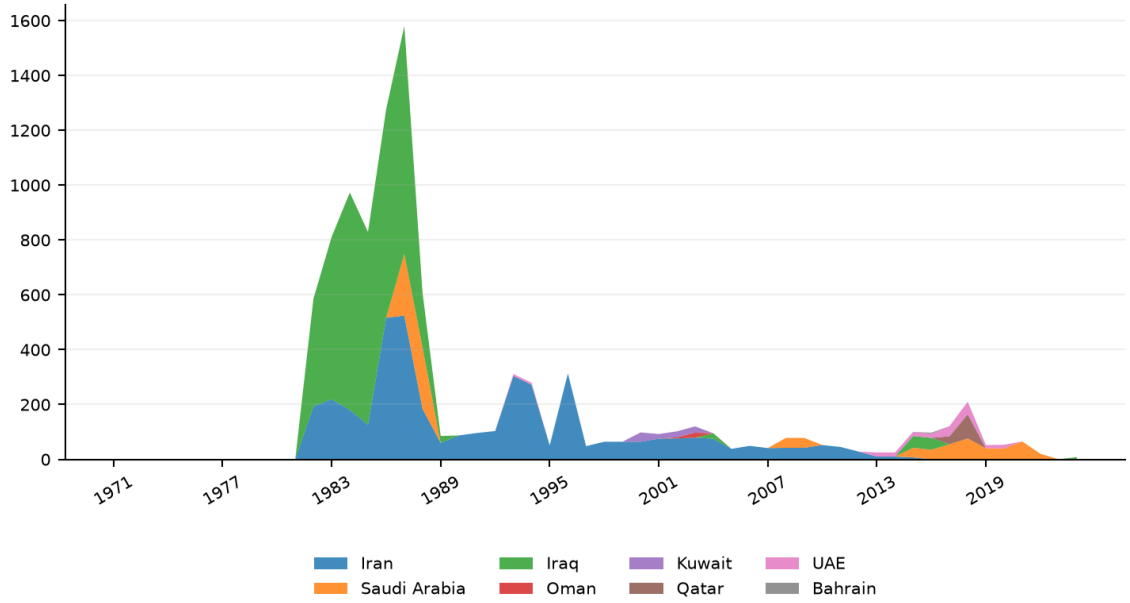


Figure 1: Chinese Arms Deliveries to the Persian Gulf (SIPRI TIV)

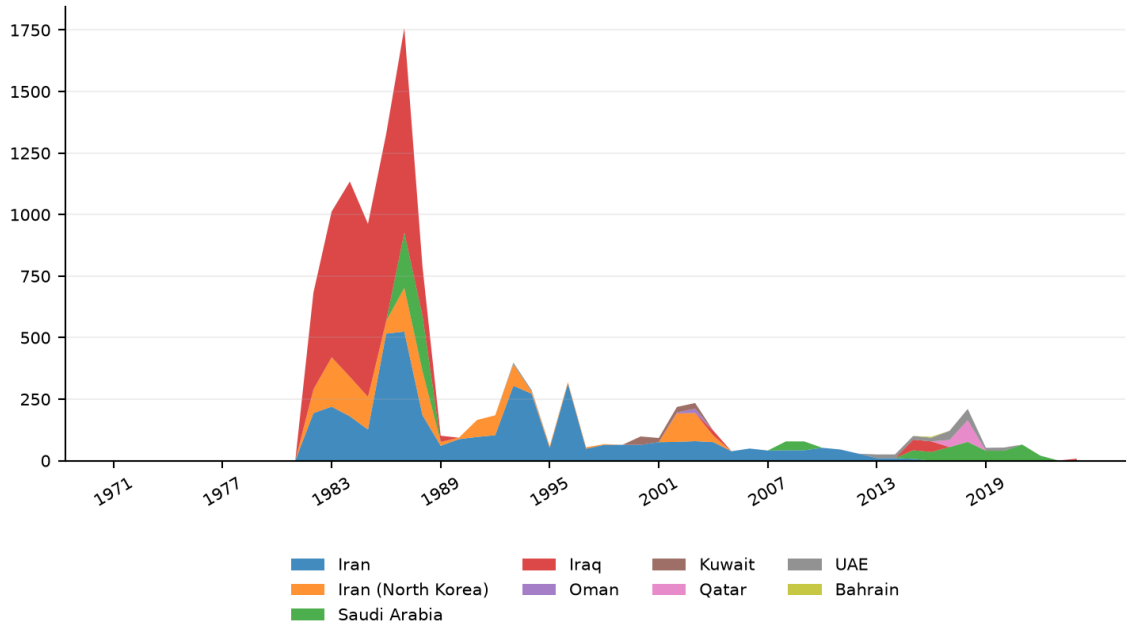


Figure 2: Chinese and North Korean Arms Deliveries to the Gulf (SIPRI TIV)

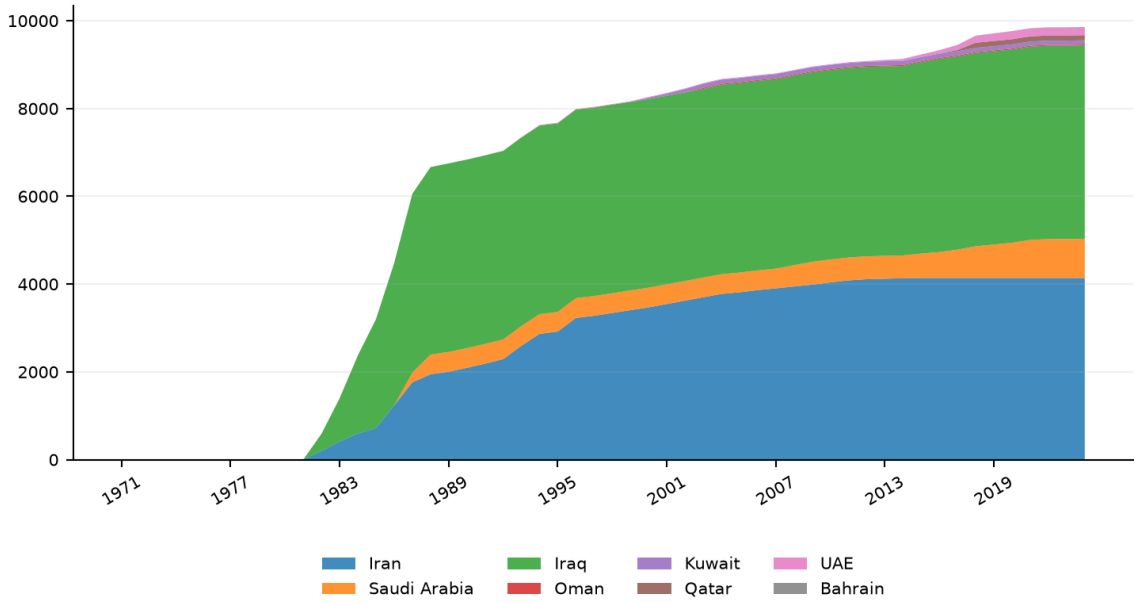


Figure 3: Cumulative Chinese Arms Deliveries to the Persian Gulf (Sipri TIV)

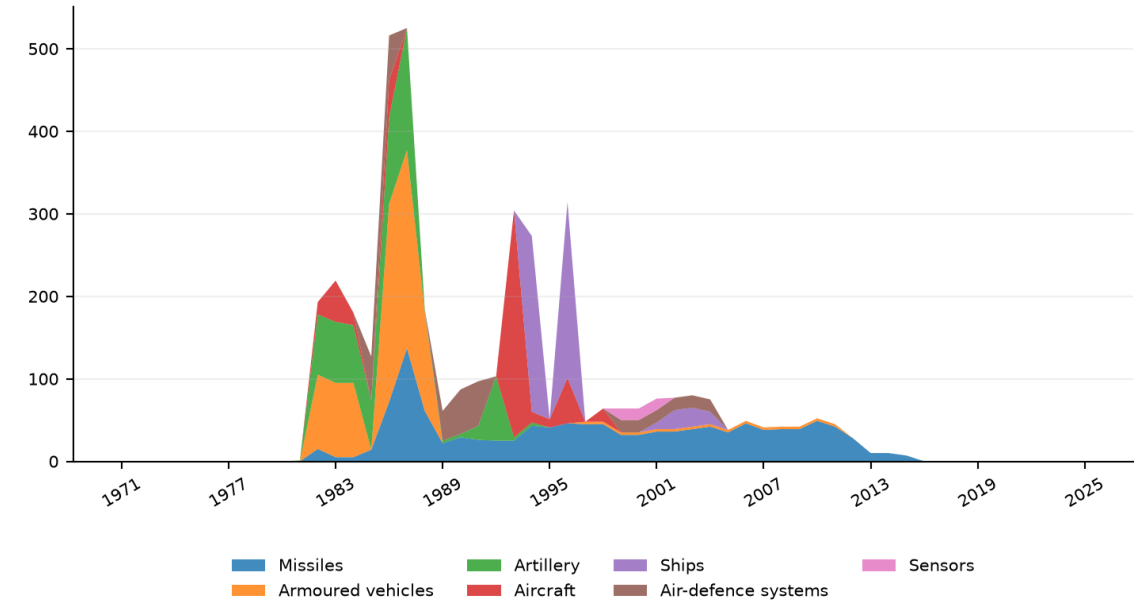


Figure 4: Chinese Arms Deliveries to Iran by Category (SIPRI TIV)

*Note that the 1994 and 1997 spikes in the 'Ships' category are due to shipments of on-board missile systems as opposed to actual vessels

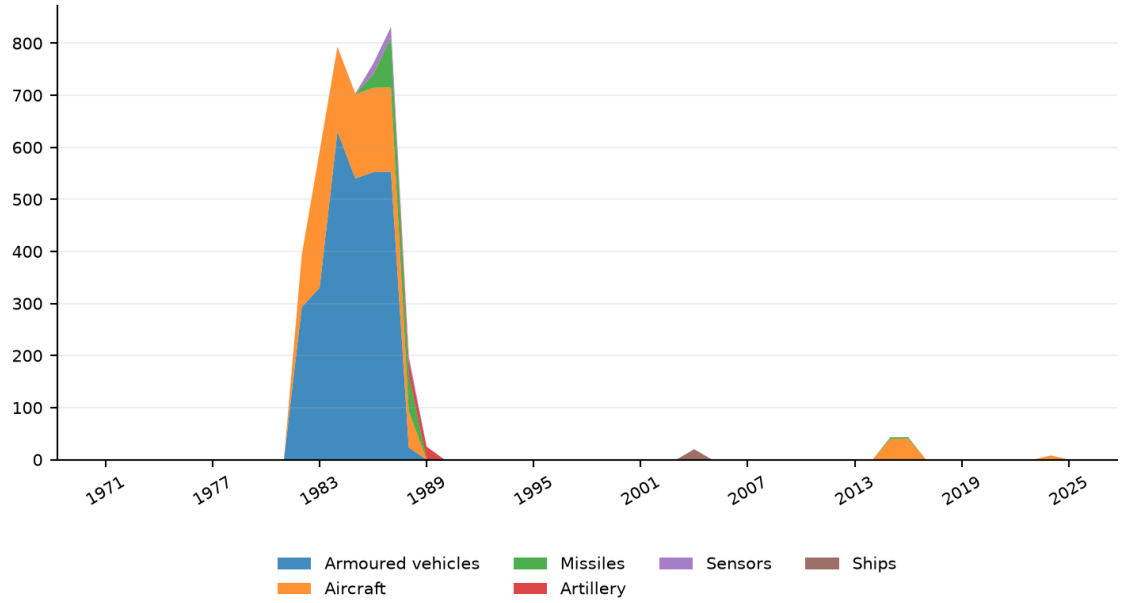


Figure 5: Chinese Arms Deliveries to Iraq by Category (SIPRI TIV)

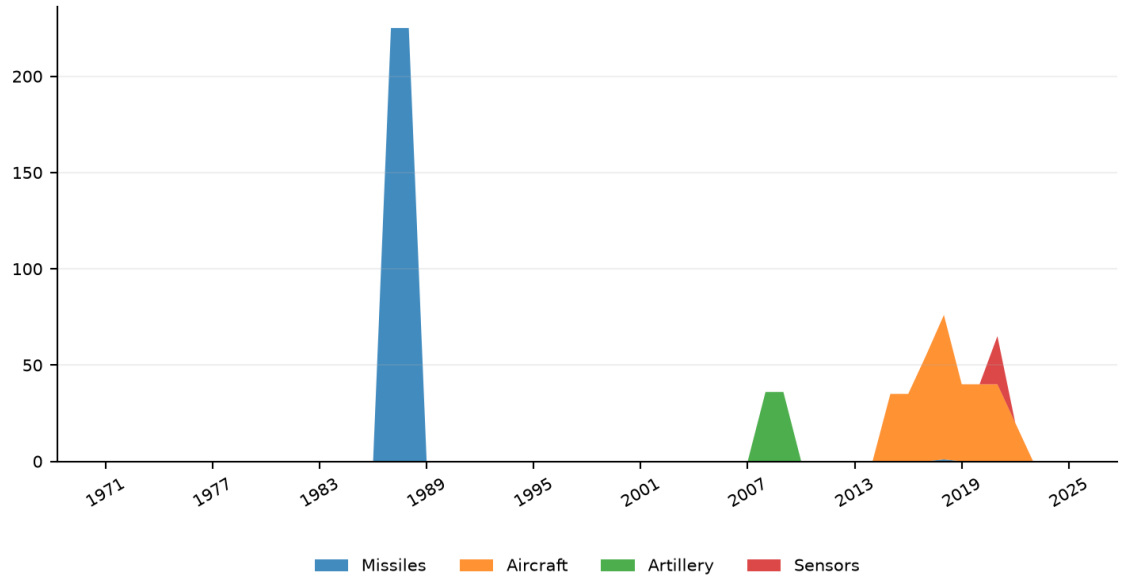


Figure 6: Chinese Arms Deliveries to Saudi Arabia by Category (SIPRI TIV)

5.2: Interpreting the Sino-Iranian Security Relationship

The data on China's Arms exports to the Persian Gulf provides quantitative support for the existing pessimistic academic consensus regarding Sino-Iranian security relations across several areas. The first, and most apparent of these is the fact that Iran has generally not been the dominant regional destination for Chinese arms exports, with the exception of a brief period in the 1990s coinciding with the delivery of several high-value systems such as the F-7N Airguard (Chinese derived Mig-21) and C-802 anti-ship missiles. The second is that China has largely complied with sanctions against Iran since 2010, with deliveries plummeting to the point of irrelevance by 2010. Correlating with this observation is the fact that the ratio of supplies delivered to Iran decreased rather than increased during periods when Iran has faced significant tension, notably during the period of the Iran-Iraq war and the 2019 Persian Gulf Crisis. Indeed, China's sale of DF3 missiles to Saudi Arabia (the significant Saudi spike in the late 80s) highlights its willingness to provide capabilities tailor-made to counter those of Iran.

The qualitative dimension of China's weapons exports has not been in Iran's favour either: While China's transfers to Saudi Arabia and the UAE have generally been in high-end weapons categories such as drones, self-propelled artillery and sensors, its historic deliveries to Iran contain significant quantities obsolete-upon-arrival equipment.[131] This difference is largely a result of Iran's international isolation: with far less restricted access to Western offerings, the Arab States have been able to concentrate their purchase of Chinese arms on those areas where China can provide competitive offerings or political advantage, a luxury denied to Iran for whom the very availability of Chinese arms imports has been in question.[132]

Consequently, the numbers paint a stark picture of China's security attitude towards Iran overall, suggesting that Beijing regards Tehran only as an occasionally awkward partner, security cooperation with whom is merely a matter of convenience; and China's historic significance to Iranian conventional and nuclear security is far more a reflection of Iran's isolation then China's commitment.

5.3: Interpreting the Sino-Iranian Economic Relationship

Given the similarities in the structure of China's trade with the oil-producing countries, a direct comparison of bilateral trade offers a straightforward proxy for evaluating the relative strength of economic ties between countries. The data for this section is pulled from the World Bank's World Integrated Trade Solution (WITS) database (https://wits.worldbank.org/), which the bank developed in conjunction with the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD). The compilation of data is conducted by UNSD Commodity Trade (UN Comtrade) and is generally considered reputable. Nonetheless, UN Comtrade's methodological reliance on self-reported data essentially guarantees underreporting in the case of a heavily sanctioned economy such as Iran's, and consequently, data since 2018 is best understood more as a floor than an accurate estimation.[133] For context, Reuters estimated the value of Iran's crude sales to China at USD 29 billion, a figure derived from Iranian production figures and an assumed 20% discount.[134]

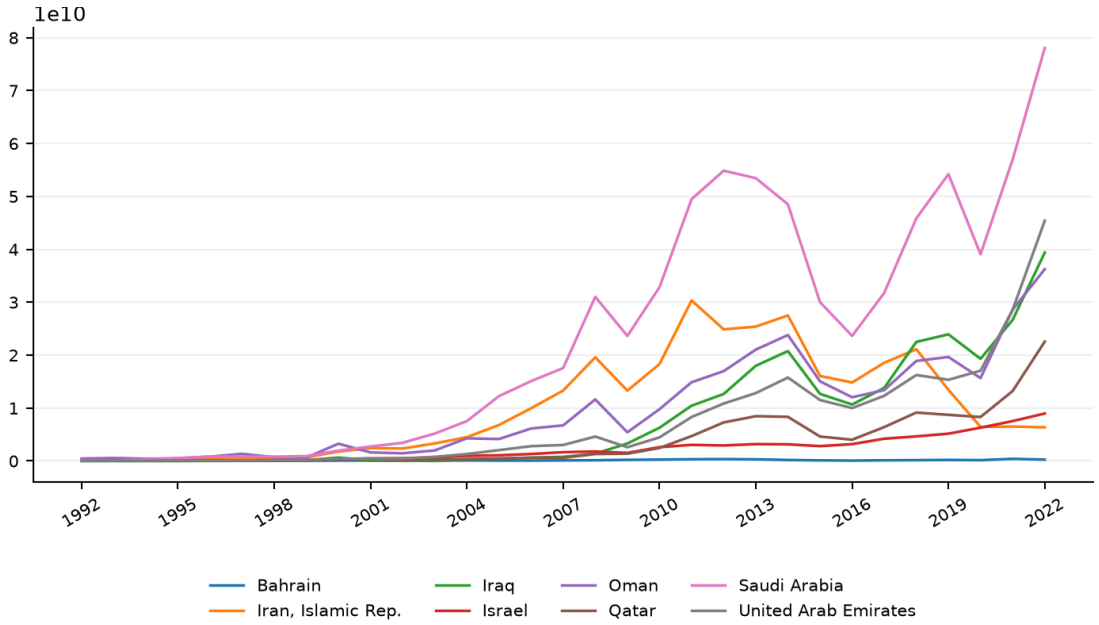


Figure 7: Chinese Imports from Selected Countries, US$

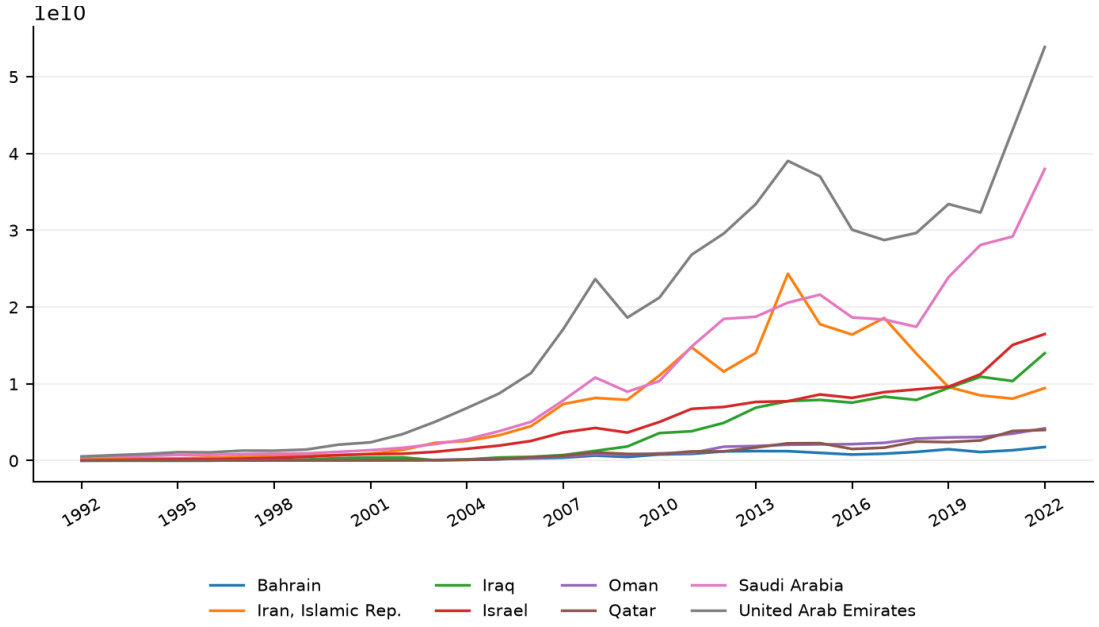


Figure 8: Chinese Exports to Selected Countries, US$

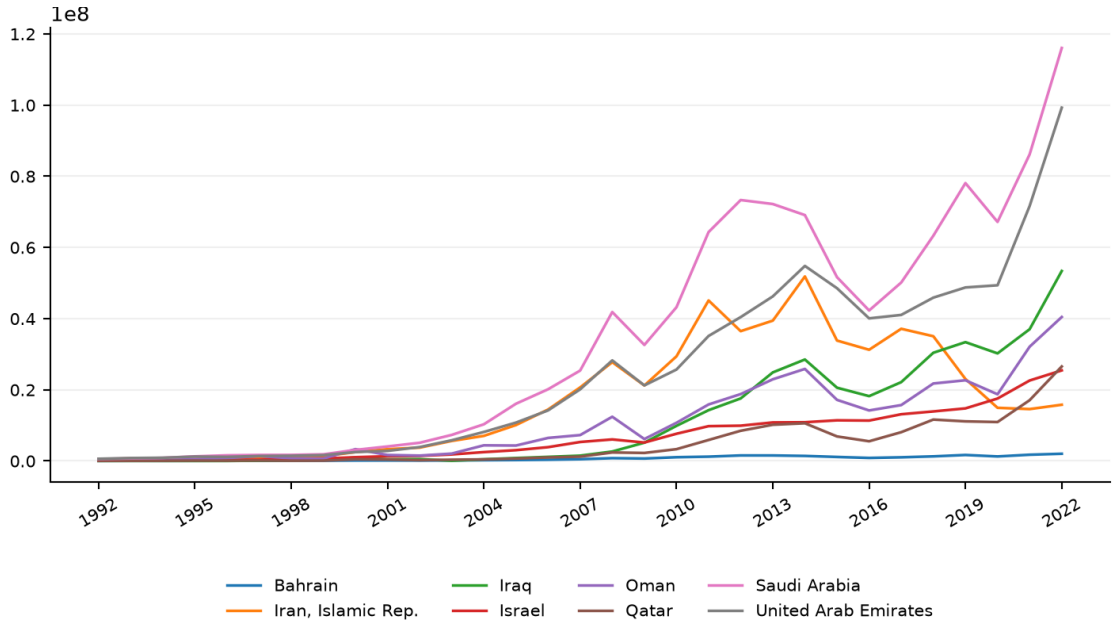


Figure 9: Percentage of Total Chinese Trade with Selected Countries by Partner

What the data makes apparent, however, is that even if one completely offsets the effect of sanctions, Iran is at best only of secondary importance to the PRC. Iran's exports to China are far less significant than those of Saudi Arabia, while its imports from the PRC are overshadowed by the UAE. Collectively, the monarchies of the Gulf Cooperation Council dwarf Iran in both exports and imports. Even Israel has on paper exceeded Iran since 2010 as a Chinese import partner. As in the case of China's arms transfers, the underwhelming reality of China's economic ties with Iran provides strong empirical backing to the pessimistic academic consensus: Beijing's economic view of Tehran is almost entirely pragmatic, a fair-weather predicated on the provision of a steady supply of discounted oil and absent any firm commitments.[135]

5.4: Quantifying Sino-Iranian Political Alignment

The use of United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) voting alignment as a proxy for geopolitical alignment is well established in quantitative studies of international relations, thanks to the ready availability and comprehensive coverage of UN records going back to 1946. Between 1998 and 2012, at least 50 studies were published using a UN-vote-based indicator as either a dependent or independent variable,[136] investigating questions ranging from whether the EU has coalesced into a foreign policy bloc[137] to the relationship between great-power economic assistance and political alignment.[138] More recently, UN voting records have been used to estimate the effect of BRI membership and voting alignment with China.[139]

This study uses voting alignment in the UNGA as the dependent variable by which China's political alignment with given Middle Eastern Countries may be estimated. The raw data source is 'United Nations General Assembly voting data: resolutions 1 (11 December 1946) to 79/278 (25 March 2025)', available via the United Nations Dag Hammarskjöld Library at https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/4060887?ln=en. This dataset is a 'compilation of the voting data related to the resolutions adopted by the General Assembly at its regular, special, emergency special sessions from its inception until the end of March 2025' and comprises 911,922 entries each consisting of one individual vote on one resolution. The data will primarily be analysed using two metrics: Signorino and Ritter's S Score and Cohen's Kappa.

Formulated in 1999, Signorino and Ritter's S Score have since become the prevailing statistical measure of foreign policy position similarity. The score is calculated using the basic formula

$$S_{ij} = 1 - \frac{2}{D \cdot V} \sum_{v=1}^{V} |y_{iv} - y_{jv}|$$

where y_{iv} and y_{jv} are vote positions for country i and j.[140] In practice, however, most research has not employed the problematic procedure of weighting and has instead relied upon a single data source such as UNGA voting records to calculate S values, a methodological approach this study will follow.[141] Doing so essentially simplifies the S-Score into a measurement of normalized average distance. This study follows will standard convention by coding yes votes as 1, abstain votes as 2 and no votes as 3, which yields a similarity measure ranging from -1 to +1 where +1 indicates perfect alignment, and -1 indicates perfect opposition.

The main limitation of the S-Score is that it represents absolute distance, and as such is not chance-adjusted based on each country's marginal vote probabilities. To account for this, a separate score will be calculated based on votes directly related to Middle-Eastern topics to reduce the effects of coincidental agreement. Moreover, the S score will be paired with Cohen's Kappa, suggested as a potential alternative metric for analysing political alignment by Häge in 2011 to limit the effect of coincidental agreement. The formula used is as follows

$$\kappa = \frac{P_o - P_e}{1 - P_e}$$

Where P_o is the actual/observed proportion of agreement and P_e is the expected agreement by chance based on marginal voting probabilities. Kappa scores similarly range from -1 to +1 with higher scores indicating greater alignment.

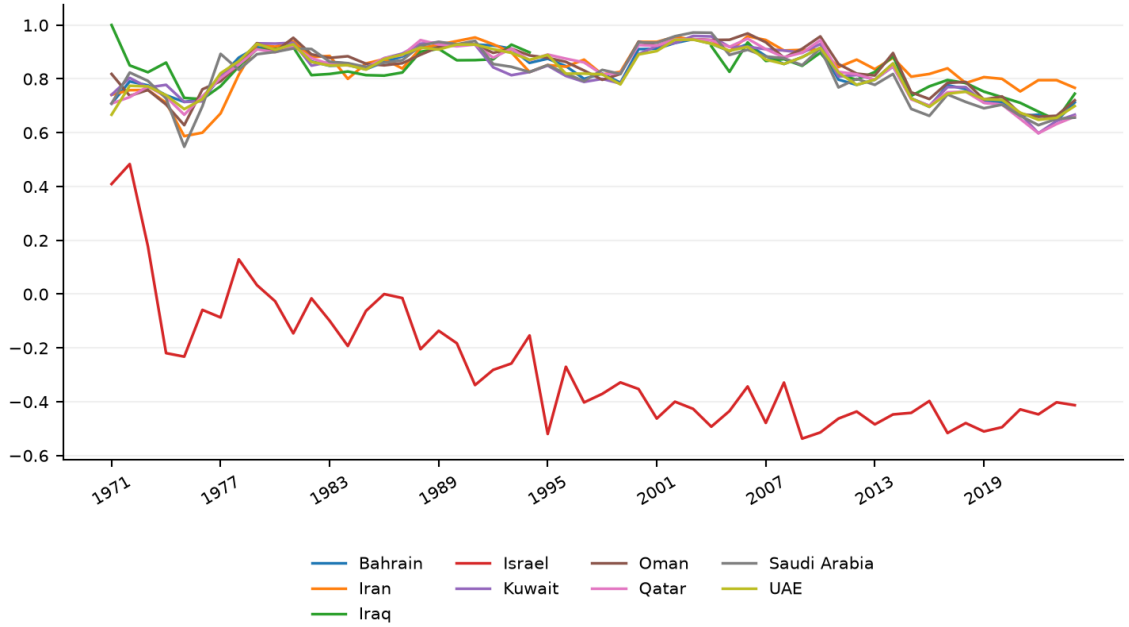


Figure 10: PRC General Assembly Voting Alignment, Signorino & Ritter's S Score

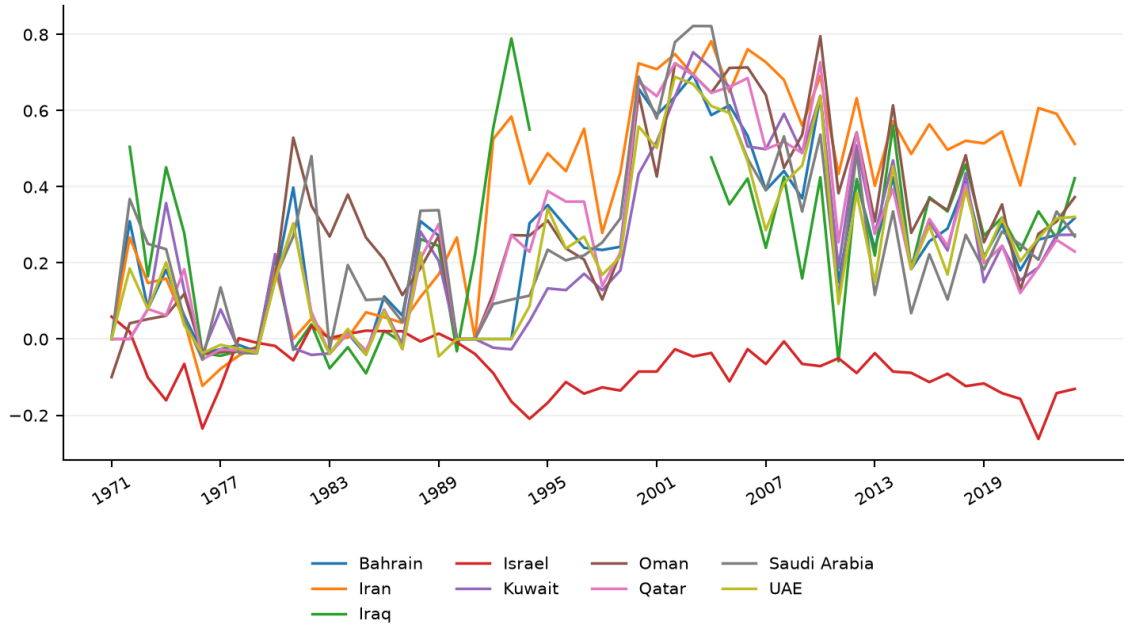


Figure 11: PRC General Assembly Voting Alignment, Cohen's Kappa

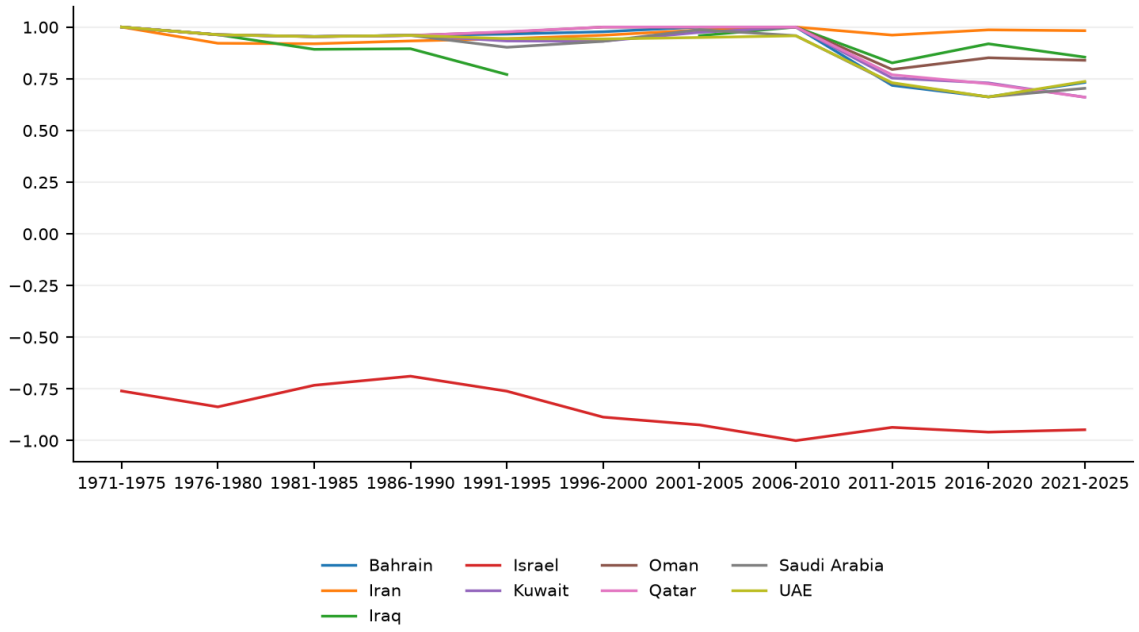


Figure 12: PRC Alignment on Middle-East Related Votes, Signorino & Ritter's S Score

The results of the data analysis once more support the existing pessimistic narrative of Sino-Iranian Relations; with the evidence once supporting the commonly accepted view that Beijing is not any more ideologically proximate with Iran than it shares with most of the region's powers, with the exception of Israel which is highly aligned with the United States politically. While Iran is closely aligned with China on many international issues, for Beijing, this only makes it one of many nations in the developing world, and is certainly no reason to grant exceptional treatment.

VI: Conclusion

This study aimed to answer a simple question: just how reliable are Sino-Iranian ties, given China's close relations with Iran's adversaries? By triangulating three empirical proxies -arms-transfer volumes (SIPRI TIV), bilateral merchandise trade (WITS), and UN General Assembly voting coincidence (κ and *S*-scores) - and by comparing in-depth the qualitative aspects of China's relations with Iran using Chinese, Western and Iranian literature – it arrives at a simple answer. In spite of the rhetoric – and only the rhetoric – China is very much not committed to the Islamic Republic.

Whether in the field of security, where China has supplied Iran with virtually no major conventional weapons since the mid-2000s; or trade, where Iran is no match for its gulf neighbours, Iran has drawn the short end of the regional straw. China has committed enough to secure cheap energy, a friendly political voice, and leverage against the US – but is unwilling to put any rhetorical skin in the game. Tehran has few such choices: internationally isolated, Iran is politically and economically reliant on China regardless of Beijing's decision-making.

This structure is unlikely to change in the near future. China has little incentive to change its balancing act, Iran little capability. To Iran, China will likely remain, frustratingly, a Friend of its Enemy who is simultaneously an indispensable friend to their own ambitions.

The full database and programs utilized in this study may be found at: https://github.com/Shun-Github1/China-Iran-Relations-Dataset.git

Acknowledgements

I would like to offer Dr Hsinyen Lai my sincerest thanks for his understanding, knowledge and invaluable guidance throughout his supervision of this dissertation. I also owe a debt of gratitude to my long-suffering friends and peers, without whose support this dissertation would not have been possible. In the highly unlikely event that they do end up reading it, they'll know who they are.

Last but not least, a million thanks to my parents, whose unwavering support throughout my life in St Andrews and beyond I am beyond fortunate to have, despite quite literally 6000 miles away.

Notes

1. Chivvis, Christopher S., and Jack Keating. "How Evil? Deconstructing the New Russia–China–Iran–North Korea Axis." In Survival: December 2024–January 2025, pp. 51-66. Routledge, 2024

2. Garver, John W. *China and Iran: ancient partners in a post-imperial world*. University of Washington Press, 2011.

3. Constantin-Bercean, Ioana. The Great Powers' Nuclear Diplomacy Toward Iran, 2003-2015. Cambridge Scholars Publishing, 2022.

4. Figueroa, William. "China and the Iranian Revolution: New Perspectives on Sino-Iranian Relations, 1965–1979." Asian Affairs 53, no. 1 (2022): 106-123.

5. Allison, Graham T. "Conceptual models and the Cuban missile crisis." American political science review 63, no. 3 (1969): 689-718.

6. 王晓波. "当代中国外交历史分期问题述评." 延边大学学报□社会科学版 6(2010):6.

7. Cheng, Joseph Yu-Shek, and Franklin Wankun Zhang. "Chinese foreign relation strategies under Mao and Deng: a systematic and comparative analysis." Kasarinlan: Philippine Journal of Third World Studies 14, no. 3 (1999): 91-114.

8. Jian, Chen. "Bridging Revolution and Decolonization: The "Bandung Discourse" in China's Early Cold War Experience." The Chinese Historical Review 15, no. 2 (2008): 207-241.

9. Friedman, Jeremy. Shadow cold war: The Sino-Soviet competition for the third world. UNC Press Books, 2015.

10. Jian, Chen. "From Mao to Deng: China's changing relations with the United States." Rivista italiana di storia internazionale 2, no. 2 (2019): 209-234.

11. Kim, Samuele S. China and the world: Chinese foreign policy faces the new millennium. Routledge, 2018.

12. Cai, Kevin. China's Foreign Policy Since 1949: Continuity and Change. Routledge, 2022.

13. Ye, Xiaodi. "Rediscovering the transition in China's national interest: A neoclassical realist approach." Journal of Current Chinese Affairs 48, no. 1 (2019): 76-105.

14. Lanteigne, Marc. Chinese foreign policy: an introduction. Routledge, 2019.

15. Mearsheimer, John J. *The tragedy of great power politics (Updated edition)*. WW Norton & Company, 2003.

16. ChinaPower Project, https://chinapower.csis.org/

17. Itakura, Ken. "Evaluating the impact of the US–China trade war." *Asian Economic Policy Review* 15, no. 1 (2020): 77-93; Liu, Tao, and Wing Thye Woo. "Understanding the US-China trade war." *China Economic Journal* 11, no. 3 (2018): 319-340.

18. Murphy, Dawn C. *China's rise in the Global South: the Middle East, Africa, and Beijing's alternative world order*. Stanford University Press, 2022.

19. 杨力, 任嘉. ""一带一路" 框架下中国—伊朗经济合作与伙伴关系构建." 新丝路学刊 (2019).

20. 中国热点外交的理论与案例研究:以中东热点问题为例. 世界知识出版社, 2017.

21. Nathan, Andrew James, and Andrew Scobell. China's search for security. Columbia University Press, 2012.

22. Burton, Guy. China and Middle East conflicts: responding to war and rivalry from the Cold War to the present. Routledge, 2020.

23. Andrews-Speed, Philip, and Yao Lixia. "China's evolving energy relations with the Middle East." In Routledge Handbook on China–Middle East Relations, pp. 227-244. Routledge, 2021.

24. Hindy, Lily. "A Rising China Eyes the Middle East." (2017).

25. Eslami, Mohammad, and Maria Papageorgiou. "China's increasing role in the Middle East: Implications for regional and international dynamics." Georgetown Journal of International Affairs 2 (2023).

26. Jonathan Fulton, written testimony before the U.S.-China Economic and Security Review Commission, Hearing on China and the Middle East, April 19, 2024, 1.

27. Scobell, Andrew, and Alireza Nader. China in the Middle East: The wary dragon. RAND corporation, 2016.

28. Shichor, Yitzhak. "See No Evil, Hear No Evil, Speak No Evil: Middle Eastern Reactions to Rising China's Uyghur Crackdown." Griffith Asia Quarterly 3, no. 1 (2015): 62-85.

29. U.S.-China Economic and Security Review Commission. Chapter 5: China and the Middle East, in 2023 Annual Report to Congress. Washington, DC: USCC, 2024.

30. Garver, John W. *China and Iran: ancient partners in a post-imperial world*. University of Washington Press, 2011.

31. Pierre Razoux , The Iran–Iraq War, trans. Nicholas Elliot (London: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2015).

32. Katzman, Kenneth. "Iran's foreign policy." Library of Congress, Congressional Research Service, 2015.

33. Kenneth Katzman, Iran's Foreign Policy and Regional Ambitions (Washington, D.C.: Congressional Research Service, 2020).

34. Frederic Wehrey, Beyond Sunni and Shia: The Roots of Sectarianism in a Changing Middle East (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2017).

35. Hunter, Shireen T. *Iran's foreign policy in the post-Soviet era: resisting the new international order*. Bloomsbury Publishing USA, 2010.

36. Gawdat Bahgat, "Iran's Nuclear Program: A Cost–Benefit Analysis," Middle East Journal 60, no. 2 (2006): 345–365.

37. Malakoutikhah, Zeynab. "Iran: Sponsoring or combating terrorism?." Studies in Conflict & Terrorism 43, no. 10 (2020): 913-939.

38. Ramazani, Rouhollah K. "Ideology and pragmatism in Iran's foreign policy." *The Middle East Journal* 58, no. 4 (2004): 1-11.

39. Warnaar, Maaike. *Iranian foreign policy during Ahmadinejad: Ideology and actions*. Springer, 2013.

40. Tayebipour, Meysam. Ayatollah Khomeini Through the Lens of the Iran-Iraq War. Palgrave Macmillan, 2023.

41. Wehrey, Frederic, Jerrold D. Green, Brian Nichiporuk, Alireza Nader, and Lydia Hansell. *The Rise of the Pasdaran: Assessing the Domestic Roles of Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guards Corps*. Rand Corporation, 2008.

42. Zarif, Mohammad Javad. "What Iran really wants: Iranian foreign policy in the Rouhani era." *Foreign Affairs* 93, no. 3 (2014): 49-59.

43. Garver, John W. *China and Iran: ancient partners in a post-imperial world*. University of Washington Press, 2011.

44. Azad, Shirzad. *Iran and China: A new approach to their bilateral relations*. Rowman & Littlefield, 2017.

45. Conduit, Dara, and Shahram Akbarzadeh. "Great power-middle power dynamics: The case of China and Iran." *Journal of Contemporary China* 28, no. 117 (2019): 468-481.

46. Garver, John W. "Is China playing a dual game in Iran?." *The Washington Quarterly* 34, no. 1 (2011): 75-88.

47. Mackenzie, Peter. "A closer look at China-Iran relations." *CNA Roundtable Discussion: China's Relations with Iran* (2010).

48. Kumar, Atul. "China's Arms Transfer to Iran: More Noise, Less Substance." *Contemporary Review of the Middle East* 11, no. 3 (2024): 267-291.

49. Belal, Kulsoom. "China-Iran relations: Prospects and complexities." *Policy Perspectives* 17, no. 2 (2020): 47-66; Grajewski, Nicole. "An Illusory Entente: The Myth of a Russia-China-Iran "Axis"." *Asian Affairs* 53, no. 1 (2022): 164-183.

50. Temiz, Kadir. Chinese foreign policy toward the Middle East. Routledge, 2021.

51. Scobell, Andrew, and Alireza Nader. China in the Middle East: The wary dragon. RAND corporation, 2016.

52. 杨兴礼, 冀开运, 陈俊华, & 杨珊珊. (2013). 现代中国与伊朗关系. 时事出版社.

53. 华黎明. "伊朗核问题与中国中东外交." 阿拉伯世界研究 6 (2014): 5-6.

54. 李希雅, 杜德斌, 陈俊华, & 夏启繁. "地缘位势视角下中美俄与伊朗的地缘关系解析." 热带地理 41, no. 6 (2021): 1153-1165.

55. Shariatinia, Mohsen. "Iran-China Relations: An overview of critical factors." *Iranian Review of Foreign Affairs* 1, no. 4 (2011): 57-85.

56. Figueroa, William. "China and the Iranian Revolution: New Perspectives on Sino-Iranian Relations, 1965–1979." Asian Affairs 53, no. 1 (2022): 106-123.

57. Garver, John W. China and Iran: ancient partners in a post-imperial world. University of Washington Press, 2011.

58. Dorraj, Manochehr, and Carrie L. Currier. "Lubricated with oil: Iran-China relations in a changing world." *Middle East Policy* 15, no. 2 (2008).

59. Putz, Catherine. *Edition: Which Countries Are for or Against China's Xinjiang Policies?" The Diplomat, October 9, 2020*. 2020.

60. Belal, Kulsoom. "China-Iran relations: Prospects and complexities." *Policy Perspectives* 17, no. 2 (2020): 47-66.

61. Garver, John W. China and Iran: ancient partners in a post-imperial world. University of Washington Press, 2011.

62. Azad, Shirzad. Iran and China: A new approach to their bilateral relations. Rowman & Littlefield, 2017

63. Figueroa, William. "China and the Iranian Revolution: New Perspectives on Sino-Iranian Relations, 1965–1979." Asian Affairs 53, no. 1 (2022): 106-123.

64. Burton, Guy. China and Middle East conflicts: responding to war and rivalry from the Cold War to the present. Routledge, 2020.

65. Currier, Carrie Liu, and Manochehr Dorraj. "In arms we trust: The economic and strategic factors motivating China-Iran relations." Journal of Chinese Political Science 15 (2010): 49-69.

66. Razoux, Pierre. The Iran-Iraq War. Harvard university press, 2015.

67. Bill Gertz, "China assists Iran, Libya on Missiles," Washington Times, June 16, 1998, A1, A14.

68. Gill, Bates. "Chinese arms exports to Iran." China Report 34, no. 3-4 (1998): 355-379.

69. Davis, Marybeth, James Lecky, Torrey Froscher, David Chen, Abel Kerevel, and Stephen Schlaikjer. China-Iran: A limited partnership. US-China Economic and Security Review Commission, 2012.

70. Lotfian, Saideh. "Threat Perception and Military Planning in Iran: credible scenarios of conflict and opportunities for confidence building." *Military Capacity and the Risk of War* (1997): 195-215.

71. Davis, Marybeth, James Lecky, Torrey Froscher, David Chen, Abel Kerevel, and Stephen Schlaikjer. China-Iran: A limited partnership. US-China Economic and Security Review Commission, 2012.

72. Garver, John W. China and Iran: ancient partners in a post-imperial world. University of Washington Press, 2011.

73. Presidential Communication to Congress, “Agreement for Nuclear Cooperation.”

74. Davis, Marybeth, James Lecky, Torrey Froscher, David Chen, Abel Kerevel, and Stephen Schlaikjer. China-Iran: A limited partnership. US-China Economic and Security Review Commission, 2012.

75. Kumar, Atul. "China’s Arms Transfer to Iran: More Noise, Less Substance." Contemporary Review of the Middle East 11, no. 3 (2024): 267-291.

76. Cheng, Victoria. "Case Study on smuggling sensitive US-origin items through Chinese front companies to Iranian military entities." Institute for Science and International Security, August 12 (2024).

77. Calabrese, John. "China’s “one belt, one road”(OBOR) initiative: envisioning Iran’s role." In China's Presence in the Middle East, pp. 174-191. Routledge, 2017.

78. Iran Seeks China Investment to Build Refineries”, Reuters, 11 June 2012, www. reuters.com/article/iran- china-investment- idUSPEK33142220090713

79. Davis, Marybeth, James Lecky, Torrey Froscher, David Chen, Abel Kerevel, and Stephen Schlaikjer. China-Iran: A limited partnership. US-China Economic and Security Review Commission, 2012.

80. Hong, Zhao. "China's Dilemma on Iran: between energy security and a responsible rising power." Journal of Contemporary China 23, no. 87 (2014): 408-424.

81. Downs, Erica, and Suzanne Maloney. "Getting China to sanction Iran-The chinese-iranian oil connection." Foreign Aff. 90 (2011): 15.

82. Scita, Jacopo. "China–Iran relations: A low-quality comprehensive strategic partnership." In Routledge Handbook on China–Middle East Relations, pp. 168-180. Routledge, 2021.

83. Chivvis, Christopher S., and Jack Keating. "Cooperation Between China, Iran, North Korea, and Russia: Current and Potential Future Threats to America." (2024).

84. Poh, Angela. "Sanctions with Chinese characteristics: rhetoric and restraint in China's diplomacy." (2020): 1-350.

85. Scita, Jacopo. "China-Iran Relations Through the Prism of Sanctions." Asian Affairs 53, no. 1 (2022): 87-105.

86. Binder, David. "Greece, Turkey, and NATO." Mediterranean Quarterly 23, no. 2 (2012): 95-106

87. Conduit, Dara, and Shahram Akbarzadeh. "Great power-middle power dynamics: The case of China and Iran." Journal of Contemporary China 28, no. 117 (2019): 468-481.

88. Herz, John H. "Idealist internationalism and the security dilemma." *World politics* 2, no. 2 (1950): 157-180.

89. Waltz, Kenneth N. "The anarchic structure of world politics." International politics: enduring concepts and contemporary issues (1979): 29-49.

90. Wendt, Alexander. Social theory of international politics. Vol. 67. Cambridge university press, 1999.

91. Keohane, Robert O. "International institutions: Two approaches." In International organization, pp. 171-188. Routledge, 2017.

92. Razoux, Pierre. The Iran-Iraq War. Harvard university press, 2015.

93. Keynoush, Banafsheh. Saudi Arabia and Iran: Friends or Foes?. New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2016.

94. McGinn, Jack. "Saudi Arabia and Iran: Beyond Conflict and Coexistence." LSE Middle East Centre Report (2018): 1-13.

95. Turner, Randall G. "Balance of power theory, implications for the US, Iran, Saudi Arabia, and a new arms race." PhD diss., Monterey California. Naval Postgraduate School, 2008.

96. Al-Tamimi, Naser. "China and Saudi Arabia: from enmity to strategic hedging." In Routledge Handbook on China–Middle East Relations, pp. 137-154. Routledge, 2021.

97. IHS Markit, Saudi Arabia Country Monitor November 2020

98. Foley, Sean. "OBOR and the dawn of a new era in Sino-Saudi ties." In *China's Presence in the Middle East*, pp. 67-87. Routledge, 2017.

99. Shapir, Yiftah, and Yoel Guzansky. "INSS Insight No. 520, February 24, 2014 Saudi Arabia's New Missile Force."

100. Duan, Xiaolin, and Shafi Aldamer. "The Saudi Arabia–China relationship at a crossroad: A neoclassical realist analysis." Asian Politics & Policy 14, no. 1 (2022): 114-128.

101. Ali-Khan, Veena. "The Saudi–Iranian Détente Has Proved Vital for De-escalation. But Regional War Could Still Break It." (2024).

102. Eslami, Mohammad, and Saba Sotoudehfar. "Iran–UAE relations and disputes over the sovereignty of Abu Musa and Tunbs." In The geopolitics of Iran, pp. 343-361. Singapore: Springer Singapore, 2021.

103. Juneau, Thomas. "The UAE and the war in Yemen: from surge to recalibration." In Survival August-September 2020: Crisis and response, pp. 183-208. Routledge, 2023.

104. Ekhtiari Amiri, Reza, Hamzeh Safavi Homami, and Mohammad Reza Mohammadi. "Iran's Geopolitical Power and the Normalization of Relations Between the UAE and Israel." فصلنامه بین المللی ژئوپلیتیک 19, no. 4 (2023): 173-199.

105. Huwaidin, Mohamed Bin. "China's strategic partnership with the UAE: Foundation and prospects." Comparative Strategy 41, no. 3 (2022): 296-313.

106. Embassy of the UAE in Beijing. "Bilateral Relations," 2020, https://sp.mofaic.gov.ae/EN/DiplomaticMissions/Embassies/Beijing/AboutEmbassy/Pages/BilateralRelations.aspx (accessed May 28, 2020).

107. Fulton, Jonathan. "China-UAE relations in the Belt and Road era." Journal of Arabian Studies 9, no. 2 (2019): 253-268.

108. Eslami, Mohammad, and Maria Papageorgiou. "China's increasing role in the Middle East: Implications for regional and international dynamics." Georgetown Journal of International Affairs 2 (2023).

109. Reuters. "China Maintains Stance on Disputed Gulf Islands Despite Iran's Anger." June 3, 2024. https://www.reuters.com/world/china-maintains-stance-disputed-gulf-islands-despite-irans-anger-2024-06-03/.

110. Rezaei, Farhad, and Ronen A. Cohen. "Iran's nuclear program and the Israeli-Iranian rivalry in the post revolutionary era." British Journal of Middle Eastern Studies 41, no. 4 (2014): 442-460.

111. Seung-Hyun, Kim. "The Israel-Iran Conflict: Historical Background and Modern." International Journal of Advanced Culture Technology (IJACT) 12, no. 2 (2024): 309-317.

112. Horschig, Doreen. "Emerging Tech and the Israel-Iran Nuclear Relationship." The Washington Quarterly 47, no. 4 (2024): 117-136.

113. Meikle, James (11 January 2012). "Iran: timeline of attacks". The Guardian. London.

114. Stevens, John; Tree, Oliver (11 October 2011). "'Factions' Of Iran's Government Behind Terrorist Plot, Holder Says"

115. Rajiv, S. Samuel C. "Deep disquiet: Israel and the Iran nuclear deal." Contemporary Review of the Middle East 3, no. 1 (2016): 47-62.

116. Abbas, Syed Qandil. "Normalization of Relations Between Israel and Arab States: An Iranian Perspective." In Arab-Israel Normalisation of Ties: Global Perspectives, pp. 181-197. Singapore: Springer Nature Singapore, 2024.

117. Scobell, Andrew, and Alireza Nader. China in the Middle East: The wary dragon. RAND corporation, 2016.

118. Yellinek, Roie. "Israel and China: Past distance, present cooperation, uncertain future." In Routledge Handbook on China–Middle East Relations, pp. 181-191. Routledge, 2021.

119. Wu, Haotan, and Dalei Jie. "Trade versus Security: Sino-Israeli Security Relations in a Game of Three Players." Asian Journal of Middle Eastern and Islamic Studies 12, no. 2 (2018): 193-206.

120. Murray, Williamson, and Kevin M. Woods. *The Iran-Iraq War: A military and strategic history*. Cambridge University Press, 2014.

121. Karsh, Efraim. The Iran–Iraq War 1980–1988. Bloomsbury Publishing, 2014.

122. Johnson, Rob. The Iran-Iraq War. Bloomsbury Publishing, 2010.

123. Burton, Guy. China and Middle East conflicts: responding to war and rivalry from the Cold War to the present. Routledge, 2020.

124. Razoux, Pierre. The Iran-Iraq War. Harvard university press, 2015.

125. Burton, Guy. China and Middle East conflicts: responding to war and rivalry from the Cold War to the present. Routledge, 2020

126. Currier, Carrie Liu, and Manochehr Dorraj. "In arms we trust: The economic and strategic factors motivating China-Iran relations." Journal of Chinese Political Science 15 (2010): 49-69.

127. Razoux, Pierre. The Iran-Iraq War. Harvard university press, 2015.

128. Scobell, Andrew, and Alireza Nader. China in the Middle East: The wary dragon. RAND corporation, 2016.

129. SIPRI Fact Sheet. "MEASURING INTERNATIONAL ARMS TRANSFERS." (2012).

130. Hagelin, B. J. Ö. R. N., and S. T. Wezeman. "Appendix 12C. Sources and methods for arms transfers data." SIPRI YEARBOOK (2004): 540-543.

131. Raska, Michael, and Richard A. Bitzinger. "Strategic contours of China's arms transfers." Strategic Studies Quarterly 14, no. 1 (2020): 91-116.

132. Yang, Chih-Hai. "Determinants of China's arms exports: a political economy perspective." Journal of the Asia Pacific Economy 25, no. 1 (2020): 156-174.

133. Chen, Chuke, Zhihan Jiang, Nan Li, Heming Wang, Peng Wang, Zhihe Zhang, Chao Zhang et al. "Advancing UN Comtrade for physical trade flow analysis: review of data quality issues and solutions." Resources, Conservation and Recycling 186 (2022): 106526.

134. Ron Bousso, "China Trade Spat Undermines Trump's 'Max Pressure' Iran Campaign," Reuters, April 10, 2025, https://www.reuters.com/world/china-trade-spat-undermines-trumps-max-pressure-iran-campaign-bousso-2025-04-10/.

135. Mackenzie, Peter. "A closer look at China-Iran relations." CNA Roundtable Discussion: China's Relations with Iran (2010).

136. VOETEN, Erik. Data and Analyses of Voting in the UN General Assembly. 17 de julho de 2012. 2012.

137. Drieskens, Edith. "Towards a Systematic Analysis of the EU as an Actor in the UN System." Journal of International Organizations Studies 1, no. 1 (2010): 105-108.

138. Flores-Macías, Gustavo A., and Sarah E. Kreps. "The foreign policy consequences of trade: China's commercial relations with Africa and Latin America, 1992–2006." The Journal of Politics 75, no. 2 (2013): 357-371

139. Belt and road initiative membership and voting patterns in the United Nations General Assembly

140. Signorino, Curtis S., and Jeffrey M. Ritter. "Tau-b or not tau-b: Measuring the similarity of foreign policy positions." International Studies Quarterly 43, no. 1 (1999): 115-144.

141. Häge, Frank M. "Choice or circumstance? Adjusting measures of foreign policy similarity for chance agreement." Political Analysis 19, no. 3 (2011): 287-305.